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KENYATTA UNIVERSITY

SCHOOL OF EDUCATION

DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATIONAL COMMUNICATION AND TECHNOLOGY

UCU 110 : COMMUNICATION AND COLLABORATIVE SKILLS

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INTRODUCTION

This course is aimed at helping you to develop the capacity to communicate effectively and efficiently in a variety of contexts, learn independently, collaborate with others, think critically as well as become an information literate citizen. This is a skills based course, which is taken by all the first year students across disciplines at the university. Since communication and collaboration are key 21st century skills, you will be given space to practice them through a variety of activities and a collaborative research project. The activities are spread out within the course topics and they are here referred to as ‘**e-tivities**’. The project is based on an argumentative essay topic that you will be guided to choose from one of your core units. The project, which is one of the spaces in which you will practice the skills covered in various topics, will run parallel with the coverage other content. **See Table 8.10.4: Group project schedule in lesson 8 of this course.**

Welcome to the course.

COURSE LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this course, the learner should be able to:

1. Communicate effectively orally and in writing in academic and other settings.
2. Listen to oral presentations, take relevant notes and answer questions on the same.

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3. Prepare and use study schedules.
4. Access, evaluate, and use library and other information resources for academic and other purposes.
5. Carry out research and present the findings in academic and work related forums.
6. Apply information literacy and information ethics skills and competencies for academic and lifelong learning.
7. Work creatively in groups to carry out research projects.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

This is a common unit for all the first year students across disciplines. It will be covered in 39 hours, some of which will be spent on online interactions. The focus is on helping you develop effective ways of fitting into college study and a range of transferrable skills. The skill areas covered are **Fundamentals of Communication and Collaboration, Collaboration and empathic listening, Oral Skills, Reading Skills, Information Literacy and Ethics, Collaboration and interpersonal skills, Study skills, and Advanced writing skills.** Note also, there is a project embedded in the learning of these skills to help you practice the skills as you cover them. Your mastery of these skills will give you an edge in the 21st century environment.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

The course is for first year students to help them learn effectively in all areas of specialization. It is, therefore, a requirement for graduation. Every student at the university needs to attain a pass or above in UCU 100: Communication and Collaboration Skills.

You will be expected to contribute to the forums by posting your responses and comments on other posts as indicated in the e-tivities . It will be helpful to work on the assigned readings before posting or responding to questions. This will make your interactions more enjoyable.

Type all your work in font 12 Times new Roman (unless guided otherwise) with the margins set as per the referencing style you use in the written work. California State University, Dominguez Hills, for example, gives details of the [American Psychological Association style, 7th edition](#).

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Be polite in all your communication. Avoid any language that might create a negative learning environment with the other learners. You will get more guidance on how to communicate and succeed in online courses by reading the three sources given below:

1. [Tips for success in online classes during coronavirus outbreak](#)
2. [Strategic study techniques](#)
3. [Making the most of your learning style](#)

Duration of Course: The course will run for one semester.

LESSON 1.0 FUNDAMENTALS OF COMMUNICATION AND COLLABORATION

1.1: Introduction

The major goal of any communicative action is to promote understanding. In the academic setting and in the professions, deeper understanding and insight are necessary. Collaborating with others in learning and at work ensures that quality ideas are shared for more effective task completion and problem solving. Therefore, the importance of communication and collaboration for learning and for assisting students prepare for their future careers cannot be overemphasized. These two competencies form part of the 4Cs (communication, collaboration, critical and creative thinking) that have been singled out as the core attributes for success in the 21st century. Communication is multidimensional and comprises all four language skills of speaking, listening, reading and writing as well as visual, interpersonal, group and intercultural and multi-disciplinary aspects. Living in a globalizing society with current advances in technology means that students and graduates experience increased need to communicate across cultures as they exchange ideas and work on international projects. Communication and collaboration are core attributes in fostering learning across all subjects and are highly sought after by employers. Inadequate communication skills and poor team skills are often seen to undermine the individual and his/her professional qualifications. The ability to communicate persuasively in presenting one's point of view and in a manner that is respectful of others are important for effective collaboration. This first lesson sets the foundation for the rest of the course in that when learning each of the other lessons, the fundamental principles of communication and collaboration discussed here will be applicable.

1.2 Lesson Learning Outcomes

- i. By the end of this Lesson you will be able to:
- ii. Explain the role of communication in promoting understanding and insight.
- iii. Discuss the key aspects involved in collaborative learning
- iv. List the benefits and conditions of collaboration in learning, the professions and personal life.

- v. Discuss the role of persuasion and assertiveness in academic and other contexts.

1.3 The Role of Communication

Communication is an active process of exchanging information between individuals using a common system of symbols, signs and behaviour (Wilkinson, 1984). It happens at intrapersonal level (internal monologue or reflection), interpersonal level, group and public and mass level. In the past, communication was viewed as having four components: sender, receiver, message and channel. Current understanding of this process now places emphasis on additional elements, which include feedback, context, barriers and effect. In addition, communication is no longer seen as a one-way process, but rather as a transaction and interaction process. In communication, meaning is not just a good or item that is passed from one individual to another, but it is more of a process of constructing meaning by taking into account the different perspectives of participants. Communication has three major functions no matter the context in which it is applied. First, it assists individuals to understand subject content, their environment, job related processes as well as themselves and others. Deep level or critical level understanding is vital in academic pursuits and in the professions where complex issues and processes need to be understood in order to offer quality services and solve problems creatively. The second role of communication is persuasion and influence. In all aspects of our life, we want to be able to persuade others of our views and be able to influence them by using spoken word, written communication and non-verbally. Communication is key in our ability to initiate and maintain human relationships at personal level, in networking and working successfully in teams.

Apart from verbal communication where participants rely on the spoken and written words, we communicate also through behaviour and non-verbal symbols and signs. Today, non-verbal competence is given equal if not more importance than verbal communication. Non-verbal aspects of communication include facial expression, gestures, body movement and posture, appearance, dressing, space and distance, tone of voice, paralinguistic features, time and artefacts. In facial expression eye contact and the smile are regarded highly. Appearance applies to our height, weight, racial features, and grooming. Time communicates powerfully about our social and intellectual qualities in that how we use time may send a wide range of meanings to those with whom we interact. What does reporting to duty all or most of the time tell about a person whether in school or at the work place?

1.4 Fundamentals of Collaboration

Collaboration involves the paring or grouping of individuals in a learning or work environment for the purpose of reflecting on an issue, completing a task, solving a problem

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or creating a product. Through collaboration, individuals achieve higher order levels of thought. The complexities of the modern globalizing and fast changing society calls for greater need for individuals to work together on issues of critical concern. In the classroom and other learning contexts, collaboration presents learners with an opportunity to interact with others, present ideas and defend their points of view, as well as share resources and exchange diverse beliefs. It also offers an opportunity to interrogate the perspectives of others and to be actively engaged in learning. Collaborative learning promotes critical and creative learning and makes learners more accountable for their own learning in that rather than work individualistically and in competition, learners in groups assist one another to learn. Collaboration provides opportunity for learners to apply a variety of skills. Leadership,

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decision-making, trust building, communication, conflict management skills enhance students' capabilities to manage their teams effectively as well as monitor task progress. It means students check how they work together as a team and how well they perform with the tasks.

E-tivity 1.4 – Fundamentals of Collaboration

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	1.4
Title	Fundamentals of Collaboration
Purpose	The purpose of this topic is to get you to find out more on the benefits of working collaboratively as well as conditions that foster successful collaboration.
Brief summary of overall task	Read the article What is collaborative learning? by Valamis and summarize the benefits on collaborative learning.
Spark	
Individual task	1. Carry out an internet study on the concepts of communication and collaboration. 2. Make brief notes on the benefits of collaboration 3. Write your answer in Assignment 4.3.2

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Interaction begins	1. With other members of your class, discuss the importance of both communication and collaboration in learning, professions and personal life. 2. Individually, write four sentences that summarise the importance of collaboration and communication in your day-to-day living. 3. Post your answers in the discussion forum 4.3.2
E-moderator interventions	I will: 1. Summarize learners' responses on task. 2. Provide direction as necessary 3. Close the e-tivity .
Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks.
Next	Persuasion and Assertiveness

1.5 Persuasion

Speaking, writing and even behaving persuasively are very important communication skills. It is vital for you to note that to be persuasive, words alone may not be enough. Some people are convincing just from the way they present themselves. They are likely to attract you way before they speak. They look presentable, walk or sit in a manner that makes you conclude they are comfortable with being who they are. They display an open inviting quality, and you may notice this from eye contact, smile or inviting gestures such as open inviting arms or body language. They choose to keep a distance that is inviting rather than one which tells that they are aloof and want to be left alone. So non-verbal behaviour does support the spoken word in our effort to persuade others to agree with our beliefs. Our writing is also a tool for persuading readers. In the education system, your examiner wants to check how persuasively you write in order to award you a pass grade. Imagine writing without following instructions, not researching the topic enough or not proofreading your writing. In an argument, you write to present evidence that should make the reader accept your conclusions.

Persuasive language whether written or spoken is used to get others to agree with our facts, share our values, accept our argument and conclusions and adopt our way of thinking. There are many ways of persuading people and they include: presenting evidence, attacking and presenting opposing views as weaker, use of inclusive language (we, us, our) that shows

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solidarity rather than (you, they, them,), use of humour, presenting cause and effect, using formal language, use of specialized jargon that shows your level of knowledge and professionalism, use of imagery and metaphors, use facts and expert opinions, statistical data as well as use of colloquial language that makes you sound down to earth and friendly.

The tone of voice is also a very potent tool in persuasion. Your tone of voice may attract or put off your listener. Consider a tone that is cheerful, reasonable, assured, tolerant, apologetic, wise, certain, persuasive, encouraging, respectful and one that is not aloof, angry, critical, resentful, judgemental, pessimistic, disappointed, biting, impatient, authoritative and disapproving.

In working with others, the ability to persuade others to pay attention to your ideas in writing as well as in conversation and even get them to believe them is a key communication skill.

1.6 Assertiveness

While some people are assertive, others are passive or aggressive. Assertiveness is the quality of being self-assured and confident. It is the ability to stand up for your own rights and those of others in a calm and positive way without being either aggressive or passively accepting others' views. Assertiveness helps you express yourself in a clear, open and reasonable manner without undermining your own or others' rights. It means you can get your point across without upsetting others or getting upset yourself. Individuals who are not assertive always say yes to others. They fear being judged, find it hard to ask questions, cannot stand up for themselves, and find it hard to express what they feel. Assertive behaviour includes the following:

- Being prepared for meetings by seeking to know ahead of time what issues may be raised and how you may need to respond.
- Being open and honest in expressing your rights, wishes, feelings and giving others room or encouragement to do the same
- Listening attentively to the views of others and responding appropriately even if you disagree with them
- Exercising self-control
- Placing yourself at the same level with others and not being authoritative
- Owning to your mistakes and apologizing while allowing others to do the same
- Appreciating others regularly for their positive actions
- Accept responsibility from others and be able to delegate to them as well

E-tivity 1.6 Assertiveness

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Numbering, pacing and sequencing	1.3
Title	Assertiveness
Purpose	The purpose of this lesson is to get you to find out more about your own assertiveness with the intention of finding out ways of increasing our level of assertiveness. The goal is find out the assertiveness techniques that may be useful for you and your team.
Brief summary of overall task	1. Watch this videos, How to talk to Anyone with ease and Confidence and Go from Passive to Assertive 2. Summarize the key points on how to build assertiveness in your interactions with others.
Spark	 Source: Heart, self-esteem, self-Liberation
Individual task	Watch the two videos above and summarize the ways of developing self-confidence and assertiveness.

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Interaction begins	1. List three techniques of developing assertiveness in your interactions. 2. In one paragraph, explain one disadvantage of being passive in your interactions. Give one specific example from your experiences. 2. Read a post from one other student and give constructive feedback.
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	3. Post your answer in discussion forum 1.6
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize learners' responses on task. 2. Provide direction as necessary. 3. Close the e-tivity.
Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 30 minutes for the group tasks.
Next	Assessment.

1.7 Assessment questions

1. The most important goal in communication is to arrive at a common understanding. True/False
2. Effective communication matters most in a work environment. True/False
3. A collaborative effort in learning cultivates critical thinking. True/False
4. It is wrong to have a team of 6 persons in a team. True/False
5. Conflict management skills are not collaboration skills. True/False

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E-References

[How to talk to anyone with ease and confidence](#)

[What is collaborative learning?](#)

LESSON 2: LISTENING AND NOTE-TAKING

2.1 Introduction

In this section, we shall look at the skills of listening and note taking. These, like many others you will learn in this course, are very important to your success in academic and other aspects of life. This means you will need to spend sufficient time in practicing the skills in order to master them.

2.2 Lesson Outcomes.

By this end of this lesson, you will be able to:

- i. Explain levels of listening.
- ii. Discuss characteristics of a good listener.
- iii. Identify barriers to effective listening in academic and other contexts and provide Possible solutions for each.
- iv. Take quality notes.
- v. Identify and explain different economical means of taking notes.
- vi. Take notes that show relative importance of ideas using different formats Such as Cornell.
- vii. Code information in diagrammatic forms such as mind maps, charts, tables, in addition, social grams among others.

2.3 Definitions

Listening is a very important, yet difficult skill to master. Most people do not even know they are poor listeners. The good news is that, just like other skills, listening can be mastered. However, what is **listening**? Is it the same as **hearing**?

This is what *Psychology Today* (2015) says about listening and hearing:

The ability to hear is typically innate, but the ability to listen well is a skill that must

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be developed and practiced. Listening means paying attention and making a conscious effort to process what you hear. It is one of our most important skills and it is one of the most overlooked.

Listening is defined in various ways. The International Listening Association defines it as “*the process of receiving, constructing meaning from and responding to spoken and /or nonverbal messages*” (International Listening Association, 1996). See more definitions below:

- i. Listening is the active process of receiving aural stimuli (De Vito, 1987:26).
- ii. Listening is a voluntary process that goes beyond simply reacting to sounds and includes understanding, analyzing, evaluating, and responding.
- iii. Listening is an active, deliberate, selective process by which a message is received, critically interpreted, and acted upon by a purposeful listener.

As the definitions above show, listening is voluntary; it is something one consciously chooses to do. Active listening is hard work because it requires concentration on what the speaker is saying. It calls for discipline and practice. For you to listen effectively, you must consciously deal with anything internal or external that might interfere with your understanding.

2.4 Levels of Listening

You will find that you listen with varying levels of concentration depending on, for example, the purpose of listening, your physical and psychological state, your background knowledge, and the content of the speech or lecture. Therefore, listening is said to be more than just a single, simple activity. There is, however, no general agreement among communication experts on a comprehensive list of levels of listening.

E-tivity 2.4 Levels of listening

Numbering	2.4
Spacing and sequencing	
Title	Levels of listening
Purpose	This activity will enable you to recognize different levels of listening. This will make you aware of how you listen in various situations.
Brief summary of	Read, For goodness sake, listen to me! in addition, discuss the different levels that you can listen.
Overall task	
Spark	Think of the difference in the way you listen to your lecturer as opposed to your parents.
Individual task	Read the text above and summarize the levels of listening.
Interaction begins	1. In one paragraph, explain how your listening can be at the cosmetic level. 2. Explain two reasons why the deep listening level helps with emotional connections. 3. Post your responses in discussion forum 2.4. 4. Give constructive comments to student's post in two sentences.

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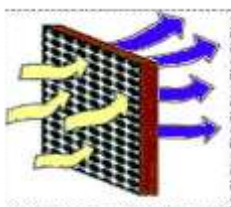
E-moderator interventions	1. Focus the group discussions 2. Give feedback with teaching points. 3. Summarise the key points of the levels of listening.
Schedule and time	The discussion will be closed in four days.
Next	Qualities of a good listener and barriers to listening.

2.5 Qualities of a good listener

Effective listening skills are nuggets for your academic and other areas of life. Being an effective and efficient listener is, therefore, a goal you should aim at achieving. Good listeners display various characteristics. They listen more and talk less, do not interrupt others, but are good at turn taking, are aware of their own biases, among many more qualities.

2.6 Barriers to effective Listening

Listening does not always proceed in a smooth manner. Each one of us has filters, some of which help us to attach meaning to the messages we receive.

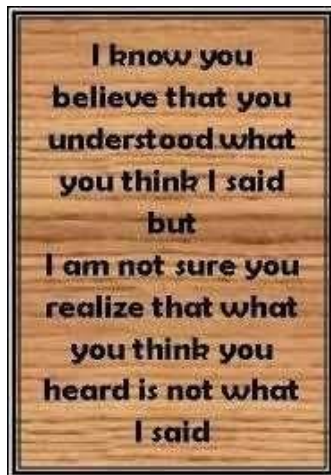


Source: <http://www.nwlink.com/~donclark/leader/leadcom.html>

However, filters can also prevent effective listening. Anything that stands in the way of effective communication is called a barrier. Due to this, it is usually difficult to attach mirror-image meanings to the messages we receive from others. Consider the following sayings, which show the level of misunderstanding inherent in listening situations:

Saying a:

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Source: Alan Keen. (2013, June 5). [The lost art of effective listening](#).

Saying b:

Nothing is so simple that it cannot be misunderstood. — Freeman Teague, Jr.

The good news is that whenever there is a potential problem, there is also a solution out there awaiting tapping by the participants in the communication event.

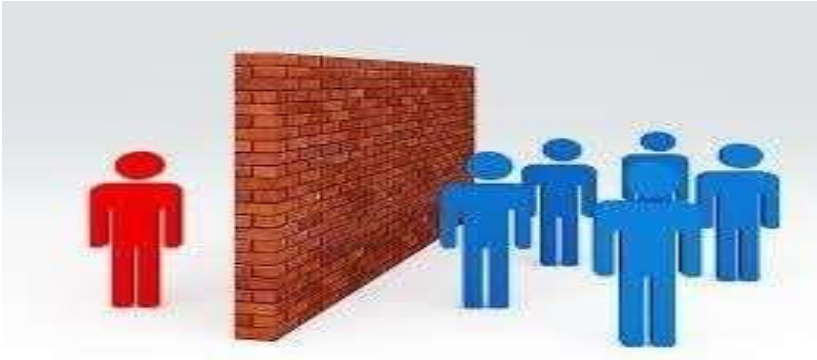
2.7 Why do we listen?

However, listening does not always proceed smoothly.

E-tivity 2.6 Barriers to effective listening.

Numbering Spacing and sequencing	2.6
Title	Barriers to effective listening.
Purpose	1. For you to be able to recognize barriers to listening in academic life and beyond. 2. For you to practice and improve on your listening skills

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Brief summary of overall task	 Source: Gwyn Teatro Read You are Not Boss of Me and discuss various barriers.
Spark	Choose any three friends in your locality to carry out this e-tivity. The first person should whisper a short message to the second person and the second person to the third person. Then the last person will say aloud what he/she heard. Find out if it was passed on correctly. (Broken telephone)
Individual task	1. Select any two barriers from the reading and suggest what you will do to rectify this. Post this in discussion forum 2.6. 2. Save this in your portfolio.
Interactions begins	From the forum, find out others that have similar barriers to yours and share ideas on how to overcome these.
E-moderator intervention Schedule and time	1. Ensure that students are discussing the task. 2. Give feedback on their discussion
Schedule and time.	The task should take two days

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Next	Note- taking.
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2.8 Note-taking

Research has shown that between 50- 80% of the content is forgotten within two weeks if no effort is made to record or to remember the material (University of Waterloo Counselling

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Services n.d). However, the amount and rate of forgetting varies among individuals. This stresses the importance of active **note taking** during a listening session and review of the notes afterwards.

Remember:

- Do not make a copy of the presenter's material, because it is **neither possible** to match the speed of delivery **nor necessary** to take down everything.
- Note taking helps you to remember both what you heard and what you understood; just record what will enable you recall the significant ideas.
- -Taking notes enables you to pay closer attention to and become more familiar with the new information.

2.9 Guidelines to Note Taking

Effective listening is crucial for your success as a university student. More so is the art of taking useful notes as you listen. A lot of new knowledge is communicated in face-to-face or virtual classrooms and it is important that you develop effective ways of noting and retrieving the information you require.

Some important points to Note:

- Record pertinent information such as:
 - o Date
 - o Title of the presentation
 - o Name of presenter or facilitator
- Use economical ways of taking notes such as:
 - o abbreviations o Symbols
 - o Acronyms (words formed from the first letters or syllables of other words)

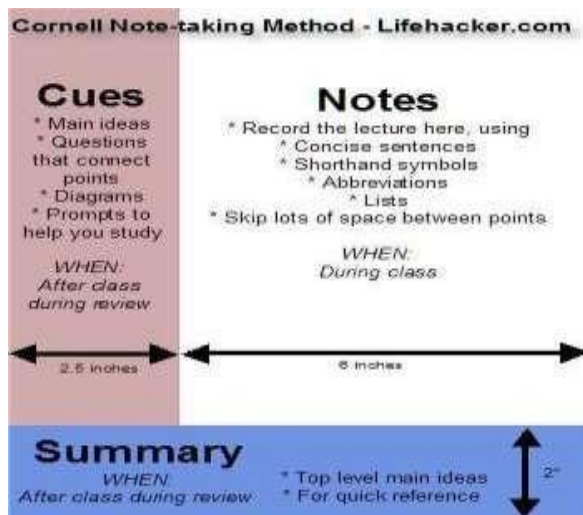
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- Omit some letters such as vowels from words
- Leave out articles (a, and, the)

2.9.1 Note Formats

Lectures or other forms of presentation vary and so the notes you take should reflect the nature of the presentation and your purpose for taking the notes. You should give your notes a structure to make them more intelligible to you. Some of the common formats are **Cornell**, **diagram**, and **outline**.

Figure 2.9.1a Cornell Notes



Source: lifehacker.com

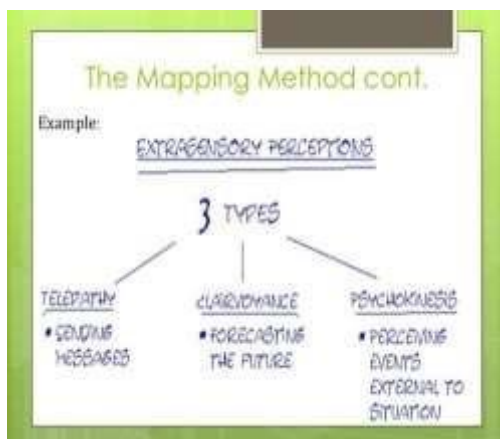


Figure 2.9.1b Diagram notes
www.slideshare.net

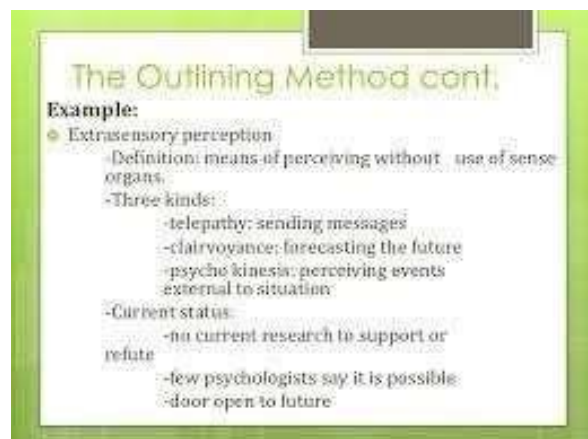


Figure 2.9.1c Outline Notes Source:

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E-tivity 2.9 Note-taking

Spacing and sequencing	
Numbering	2.4

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Title	Note-taking
Purpose	This task will enable you to write notes effectively...
Brief summary of overall task	Watch the following video on the tutorial on how to write Cornell notes.
Spark	What method do you use in writing notes during your lectures and is this effective?
Individual task	After watching the video, practise the Cornell format to write notes during one of your lectures.
Interactions begins	In your discussion, groups compare your notes and provide feedback on each other's notes. Rectify after the feedback.

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E-moderator intervention	Ensure that students do this work in their groups by collecting their work
Schedule and time	Give feedback
Schedule and time.	The work should take four days.
Next	Oral skills: Public speaking.

2.10 Topic Summary

The topic has covered various aspects of listening and oral skills. We have seen listening defined variously as an active process receiving aural stimuli and acting on it. Hearing, on the other hand, is shown as a passive, automatic process of simply perceiving sounds. Effective listening takes time and effort; it is at times very difficult, but the returns mostly justify the efforts. Poor listening, on the other hand can be disastrous and costly. The importance of active listening is underscored and note taking is seen as one of the ways of being engaged during a presentation.

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2.11 Assessment questions

Read the [following slides](#) and answer the questions below:

Listening and hearing mean the same thing. True/False

- To get maximum benefits from listening to my facilitator, I should do one of the following:
 - Write everything that I hear.
 - Listen actively
 - Make sure I hear every word spoken.
- Psychiatrist and author M. Scott Peck says, “*You cannot truly listen to anyone and do anything else at the same time.*” True/False
- Effective listening requires effort. True/False
- Taking notes helps you pay more attention to the facilitator. True/False

Hearing Vs. Listening

3.0 LESSON: ORAL SKILLS: PUBLIC SPEAKING

3.1 Introduction

Public speaking is a very important means developing empowerment at personal and societal levels. Many opportunities for you to deliver speeches are bound to arise in your academic and other fields. Public speaking, unlike general conversation, requires more systematic and detailed planning. It also demands that an effective speaker understands the audience, the context and other constraining factors that could affect the quality of delivery and the subsequent impact. This topic addresses the main stages of speechmaking: topic selection, organizing ideas, presentation, and post speech evaluation. There are exercises meant for both individual and group attention to help you practice the skills. Public speaking involves sharing your ideas with others. Like other aspects of communication, public speaking is a complex process, but it can be mastered with practice. Its success is a combination of many factors.

3.2 Lesson Outcomes.

You will be able to:

1. Select an appropriate topic for a selected purpose, audience and occasion.
2. Conduct analyses of audiences and occasions.
3. Prepare speech outlines on selected topics.
4. Present speeches on selected topics.
5. Do post-speech analysis.

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3.3 Speech Making Process

Speechmaking is a process that involves various stages.

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3.3.1 Selecting and narrowing the topic selection

Always see every subject through the eyes of your listeners/audience. It is important to tailor every topic to suit your particular audience. This should be reflected in the topic wording, among other things. Use the following criteria:

<u>Criteria</u>	<u>Question to ask</u>
Apparent worth	Is it important to you and to your audience?
Appropriateness	To your personal interests, the audience, and the occasion
Availability of material	Do not embark on a topic if researching the content will be a problem no matter how interesting it is to you.

Sometimes the topic is prescribed, but on a number of occasions, you will need to come up with your own. A good topic requires that you consider the **audience**, the **purpose** of your speech, and the speech **situation**, because these factors influence the success of your presentation.

Audience analysis

Audience analysis is your attempt at gaining some working knowledge of your prospective audience. There are at least three main areas to consider when doing audience analysis: demographics, psychological, and content factors. Read to get more information on audience analysis.

Etivity Audience analysis

Numbering	3.3.1
Spacing and sequencing	
Title	Audience analysis
Purpose	This e-tivity will help you in preparing a good speech for any particular

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	audience
Brief summary of overall task	Read A Primer on communication Studies. Chapter 9 and Communicatio 101 (Dutton) then state why analyzing your audience is important before you prepare a speech.
Spark	People walking out of the room while the speech is ongoing
Individual task	Discuss the importance of audience analysis based on the education leve and religious affiliation and post a maximum of one 150 words paragra response to the forum.
Interactions begins	Read two of the responses on the forum and give feedback on what should be corrected. Post your response in discussion forum 3.3.1.
E-moderator intervention	Stimulate further learning
Schedule and time	Provide feedback Closing the e-tivity
Schedule and time.	.This task will take three days.
Next	Organizing your ideas.

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- **Purpose**

Your purpose is what you want your audience to carry with them and what you want them to do with it .As Iacocca says:

There is no way around it – you have to do your homework. A speaker may be very well informed, but if he hasn't thought out exactly what he wants to say today, to this audience, he has no business taking up people's valuable time (Quoted in Gamble and Gamble, 1993:304).

Remember, your listeners are going to invest their valuable time and other resources, so the purpose of your speech should be worth their efforts.

Some communication experts give three main purpose categories: to **entertain, inform, and [persuade](#)**, but there are many more direct and subtle ones such as motivate, challenge, inspire, demonstrate, congratulate, educate and advise.

Remember to tailor your speech to meet the **needs** of the audience, which are quite diverse. [Maslow's hierarchy of needs](#) is one way of representing human needs. See figure 3.3.1 for details.

- **Situation**

This may also be referred to as **context** or **occasion**. Speech situation refers to the physical surroundings and the whole setup of the speech. You may find it necessary to visit the venue of the presentation ahead of time to know what to expect. It is possible that you will require certain adjustments to the physical setting or your speech.

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- **Speech situation checklist**

- Date of the presentation
- Length of the presentation
- Venue/Location
- Nature of the occasion
- Size of the audience
- Any other relevant detail

3.3.2 Narrowing the topic

Consider the situational constraints such as time and the nature of the audience as you go through the process. Start with a broad subject and brainstorm for ideas to make it manageable:
The universe-the galaxy-the stars-the type of star

Consider the topic ladder in the following example:

- Poverty eradication
 - Poverty eradication in developing countries
 - Poverty eradication in Kenya
- Poverty eradication in the arid and semi- arid areas

After narrowing the topic, do the following to make it easier for you to write out the speech:

- Formulate a purpose statement
This is a general statement, which gives an idea of what your speech is about and it is

Usually stated in the infinitive.

E.g. To inform the audience about the economic steps the government is taking in eradicating poverty.

- Write out the thesis statement.
The thesis statement focuses more on the content and the direction of the presentation.

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E.g., the government has instituted various economic measures as a way of eradicating poverty.

3.3.3 Organizing Your Ideas

Organizing your ideas in a systematic way will keep confusion to a minimum and facilitate communication between you and your audience. There are different organizational patterns in writing: **topical**, **temporal**, **spatial**, **problem-solution**, **cause-effect** and **motivated sequence**. [Read patterns of organization](#) for more explanation.

Every good speech has three main sections: the **introduction**, the **body**, and the **conclusion**. The first and the last together occupy approximately 10 to 15 % of the total speech. In other words, as the adage goes, “*Tell them what you are going to tell them, then tell them, and finally tell them what you have told them.*”

Prepare your speech outline following the three major sections of a speech: the **introduction**, **body** and the **conclusion**. The number of ideas in your speech will depend on the time available among other things. Between 4 to 6 ideas are ideal for most speeches.

E-tivity 3.3.3 organizing your ideas

Numbering	3.3.3
Spacing and sequencing	
Title	Organizing your ideas.
Purpose	This task will enable you to organize your ideas by effective planning.
Brief summary of overall task	There are various ways of organizing ideas for speeches. Read the sources below to help you to do the e-tivity: 9.6 Organization & outlines 7.13 Organizing persuasive speeches Using organizing patterns
Spark	From the way you usually organize your ideas is there a pattern of doing this?

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Individual task	State when you are required to organize your ideas in:
	1)Chronological order 2) Sequential order.
Interactions begins	1. Post your answers in discussion forum 3.3.3. 2. Give positive comments to two students.
E-moderator intervention	Ensure that the group work is done offline and work collected for correction and further learning.
Schedule and time	
Schedule and time.	The task should take 2 hours.
Next	Speech presentation and post speech evaluation.

3.3.4 Speech presentation

Effective and efficient speakers portray certain characteristics:

- Insight
 - They know their strengths and weaknesses and make no presumptions about the topics of their presentation, the audiences or contexts. An effective speaker will take time to do thorough research on all these elements and any other that might affect the quality of the presentation.
- Confidence

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- Research shows that a speaker who displays high confidence is perceived by the audience as more accurate, competent, credible, intelligent, knowledgeable, likable, and believable than one who is less confident and uncertain (Wesson, 2005).
- Connect with their audiences
- Establish eye contact with their audience
- They view the speech as if it was a performance that requires systematic planning, designing and implementation. They know they have to work hard to keep their listeners interested in what they have to say. However, they also need to take public speaking as a way of communicating with their audience. This will help in overcoming stage fright because not everything needs to be perfect to succeed.
- Are authentic in their presentations.
- Modulate their voices to avoid monotony and adjust their pitch to suit audience size
- Avoid distracting body language
- Are passionate about their presentations
- Dress well for the occasion
- Know why they are speaking and what they hope to achieve.
- Prepare well for their presentations and do thorough practice and rehearsal ahead of time.
- Make a post- speech evaluation or analyze their presentations. They believe this will feed into the next speech and lead to a better performance.

Always rehearse your presentation or do what is called a “dry run”. This may show you whether you need to improve on content or on your manner of presentation. Time yourself in order to ensure that your speech will fit in the time allocated for that purpose.. Establish the speaker -Audience -Topic S-A-T) connection. Capture their attention. Deliver the speech with confidence.

3.3.5 Post speech evaluation

Evaluation after any event is important because it helps you to identify what went well and the areas that need more attention in future. This will help you make better speeches in future. After all, the adage, “Practice makes perfect” applies very well in all stages of the speech making process. There are many ways of evaluating a speech.

E-tivity Speech presentation and post speech evaluation.

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Numbering	3.3.4 and 3.3.5
Spacing and sequencing	
Title	Speech presentation and post speech evaluation.
Purpose	The task will enable you to present a speech using any of the prescribed methods. You will be able to carry out a post analysis of your speech.
Brief summary of overall task	Read 10.1 and 10.2 of A primer on communication studies and prepare a speech for presentation.

Spark	Think of a situation where you memorized a poem to present in class and before the presentation, you could not remember a word!
Individual task	Prepare a speech of not more than 300 words on “The benefits of University education” to present to your group on the forum using a method of your choice.

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Interactions begins	In your group forum, each of you should present their speech in writing. Give feedback on the strengths and weaknesses of each other's speech. Use the link below to evaluate the speech. http://www.toastmasters.org.nz/files/docs/evaluation_template_pdf.pdf You can use Zoom or Google Meet (or any other application for synchronous meetings for this assignment).
Schedule and time.	Writing the speech takes three days and presentation on to group forum is two hours.

3.4 Assessment questions.

- The following are important in your speech preparation. Select one or more items.
 - Size of audience
 - Your voice quality
 - Context
 - None of the above
- Planning your speech is an important step in producing an excellent speech. True/False
- Effective public speakers do one or more of the following:
 - Connect with their audiences
 - Establish eye contact with their audience
 - Encourage audience participation
- One of the key elements of speech preparation is r-h- - r-a-l.
- In speech writing and presentation, S-A-T means ----- connection.

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E-References.

Listening and Note-taking

- Anonymous. (2012). A primer on communication studies (v.1.0).

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<http://2012books.lardbucket.org/pdfs/a-primer-on-communication-studies.pdf>

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<http://www.slideshare.net/karenbachmann/listen-up-improving-listening-skills-and-awareness>

3. Communication and Leadership.

<http://www.nwlink.com/~donclark/leader/leadcom.html>

4. Keen, A. (2013, June 5). The lost art of effective listening.
<http://akeen.empowernetwork.com/blog/the-lost-art-of-effective-listening>

5. Listening Chapters: Chapter 5

<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/atd-hostos-interpersonalrelations-1/chapter/listening-chapters-chapter-5/>

6. Rich, L.T. (2012, January). Note-Taking Skills.
www.slideshare.net/LauraTRich/note-taking-skills-2

7. Slideshare. (2014, May). Barriers to effective listening.
<http://www.slideshare.net/MIHIRDIXIT/barriers-to-effective-listening-34236972>

8. University of Leicester. (2010) Note-making Study Guide.
<https://cutt.ly/hsG3bj0>

LESSON 4.0 STUDY SKILLS

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Source: <http://library.ku.ac.ke/>



Source: <http://philadelphia.adl.org/2014/07/17/>

4.1 Introduction

Students often confuse studying with reading, preparing for examination or doing assignments. Unfortunately, this misconception is rarely addressed in most of the subject areas at the university, since studying as a skill is often overlooked. So what is studying? Without addressing this area, you will find yourself struggling in your academic and other aspects of life after college. The aim of this topic is to help you to think about and plan the way you should study and to improve your studying, revision and examination techniques. It will also help you in preparing for your career of choice after your university studies.

4.2 Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Explain the difference between study, reading, and preparing for exams in college.
2. Prepare general and specific study schedules/timetables.
3. Identify effective study habits.
4. <https://www.wikihow.com/Form-a-Study-Group>
5. Organize notes in notebooks, note-cards, and files (hard copy and in a computer).
6. Identify negative influences of procrastination
6. Prepare and take exams efficiently.

4.3 Lesson Outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

1. Explain the relationship between study, reading and preparing for examinations.
2. Budget for relevant items.

3. To design effective filing systems of your notes.

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4.4 Definitions of Study

Study can be defined in many ways. Sometimes you will find people use „study“ and „reading“ interchangeably. See some of the definitions given in the [Merriam-Webster dictionary](#). Whatever the definition, you will need to develop effective study skills in order to manage your time and other resources effectively and efficiently. You will need to be aware particularly of the following key aspects among others:

- The importance of effective note keeping and budgeting.
- How to organise notes
- Advantages of using notebooks, A4 papers, cards and computer e-notes
- Advantages of different filing systems
- The importance of budgeting what a student needs
- The dangers of procrastination

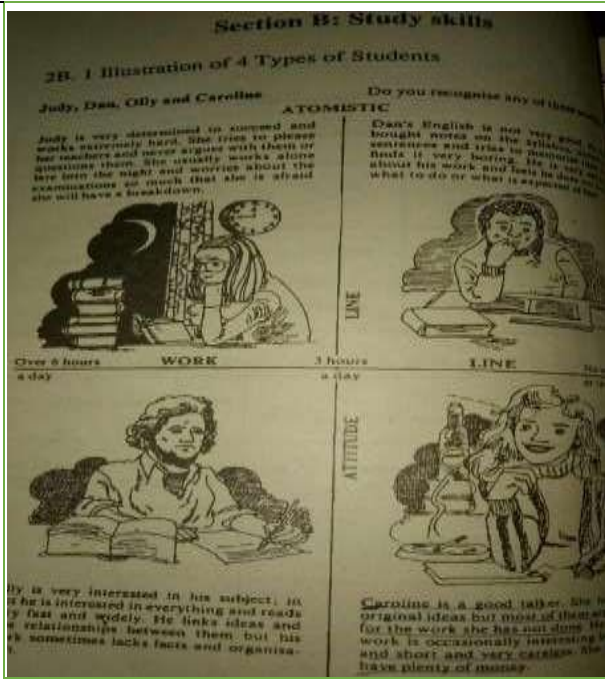
E-tivity 4.4

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	4.4.
Title	Requirement For Study
Purpose	This e-tivity will enable you to identify major reasons to help you develop effective study habits.

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Brief summary of overall task	By reading these two links, you will get information for answers on activities below. 1. http://www.differencebetween.net/language/difference-between-studying-and-reading 2. http://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/study
Spark	

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	 The image shows a page from a textbook titled "Section B: Study skills" and "2B. 1 Illustration of 4 Types of Students". It features four illustrations of students, each with a short text description of their study habits and challenges. Judy: Judy is very determined to succeed and works extremely hard. She tries to please her teachers and never argues with them or questions them. She usually works alone late into the night and worries about the examinations so much that she is afraid she will have a breakdown. Dan: Dan's English is not very good. He brought notes on the syllabus, but he finds it very boring. He is not sure about his work and feels he does not know what to do or who is responsible for it. Ody: Ody is very interested in his subject; in fact, he is interested in everything and reads a lot and widely. He links ideas and relationships between them, but his work is sometimes lacks focus and organization. Caroline: Caroline is a good talker. She has original ideas but most of them are for the work she has not done. Her work is occasionally interesting but is short and very careless. She has plenty of money.
Individual task	1. Refer to the links above and summarize the difference between study, reading and preparing for exams. 2. Post your answer in discussion forum 4.4.
Interaction begins	1. Give positive and constructive feedback to two other students. 2. Post your response in discussion forum 4.4.
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize the contributions. 2. Give feedback and learning points 3. Close the e-tivity a week from its commencement.
Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks.

Next	Information search
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4.4.1 Requirements for Study

The fact that you are learning online does not negate the need for basic learning materials such as notebooks, note cards, pens, files, staplers and staples, punches, and paper. As an online student, however, there are added demands on your finances. You will need computer software and hardware to facilitate your study. For example, a computer or iPad/tablet, and internet connectivity are basic. It is may be necessary to acquire these before you enroll for your courses.

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4.4.2 Keeping Your Notes

Note keeping is certainly not a new thing to you. By now, you must have realized that to learn from your notes effectively, you must first ensure that they are well organized for easy access. There are many options available to you for keeping your notes. You are free to choose the most convenient way for you.

4.4.3 Budgeting

Students are advised to budget all that they need in a given semester. You must take stock of all your requirements on which you are likely to spend money.

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E-tivity 4.4.1

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	4.4.1
Title	Requirement for study
Purpose	This e-tivity will enable you to identify major reasons for having effective study habits.
Brief summary of overall task	Compare and contrast use of notebooks and other forms of storage and organization.
Spark	
Individual task	Briefly explain the advantages and disadvantages of using notebooks, note-cards, files and computer files to keep your notes.

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	2. Draw a list of your budget items in order of their importance. Explain the rationale of your list and post in Assignment 4.4.1
Interaction begins	1. Comment on four posts from your peers. Have two from each question. 2. Post your answer in discussion forum 4.4.1
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize the contributions 2. Give feedback and learning points 3. Close the e-tivity a week from its commencement

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Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks
Next	Information search.

4.5 Planning a Study Schedule

Effective and efficient studying comes with a keen eye on time management. This means taking stock of all that surrounds you academically and in all aspects of your life as a student. This will call for high levels of discipline. Your 24 hours in a day will mostly appear insufficient when all you have on your hands is considered. So being able to plan for the day, week and even for a year will be very necessary.

4.5.1 How to prepare the timetable

After making the commitment to work hard, it becomes necessary to make studying part of your daily routine. When drawing the study timetable, you must consider the time available for the work and tasks that you will have to do.

4.5.3 Where to study and Time to Study

It is not easy to recommend to students not only best study places but also when to study. This is because students have unique individual preferences. Some students for example study while listening to music while others choose to study in very quiet places. Secondly, it is not possible to prescribe the best time to study since it varies from person to person. As a student, you are advised to be consistent with the time chosen.

4.5.4 How to Study

You will find a plethora of tips on how to study all of which are meant to help you cultivate effective and efficient study habits. You are advised to choose only those tips that will help you promote learning that is accompanied with understanding. Remember, —*Failing to plan is planning to fail. However, planning is only half the battle. The harder part is just doing it.*|| (<http://www.pinterest.com/explore/study-skills/?fromnavigate=true>)

E-tivity 4.5.4

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	4.5
Title	Planning a Study Schedule
Purpose	The e-tivity will help you identify important considerations needed when preparing a study timetable, when choosing a good study place, and when forming a study group.
Brief summary of overall task	Read Organizing your time and A guide for successful students for more information. The information will help you in providing answers to the activities below.
Spark	“I sit and gaze at books for hours, but I get very little done” “I can’t get the balance right; I find any excuse to put it off” “Concentration is my problem; I can’t settle to anything for very long. “I just can’t meet the deadlines; the work keeps piling up.” Francis Casey
Individual task	1. List three advantages of planning. 2. Prepare a timetable for one week covering all your academic and other activities.
Interaction begins	1. Post your answers in discussion forum 4.5 2. Read and give constructive feedback to two students.

E-moderator interventions	1.Summarize the contributions 2.Give feedback and learning points 3. Close the e-tivity a week from its commencement.
Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks
Next	Information search

4.6 Preparing for and taking exams

Examinations are one way of effectively measuring how well you have studied a certain subject or course. Success or failure in your work is determined almost entirely by your ability to perform well in your examinations. Examinations do cause anxiety. A little anxiety is good because it forces you to study, but a lot of anxiety is bad since it can incapacitate you. You will be surprised to know that though we do not like examinations, they have some benefits. Many resources address:

- Determination of success in examinations
- When preparation of examination starts
- When to start revising for examinations
- Important examination strategies
- Differences between essay and multiple type of questions

4.7 Assessment questions

1. Studying is the same as reading. True/False
2. One starts preparing for examinations when the university announces the dates of examinations. True/False
3. A study timetable should include the study and class hours only. True/False
4. A little anxiety is good because it forces you to study, but a lot of anxiety is bad since it can i-a-acita-- you.
5. Cheating in an examination can earn one expulsion from college. True/False

7.8 E-References

1. Coffman, J.P. (n.d). Organizing your time.

<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/collegesuccess/chapter/2-3-organizing-your-time/>

2. A guide to successful students.

<https://ecampusontario.pressbooks.pub/studyprocaff/chapter/successful-students-get-it-together/>

LESSON 5.0 COLLABORATION AND INTERPERSONAL SKILLS

5.1 Introduction

Teamwork has become the new norm in the 21st century whether in academics, work, or other aspects of life. One of the definitions of a team is “a group of people who come together to work in an interrelated manner towards a common goal” (McChan, et al., 2015). Well performing groups will have defined roles, and a set of norms to guide their operations. See Figure 5.0 for a summary.

Figure 5.0



GRIP Model of teamwork dynamics

Source:

<https://pressbooks.bccampus.ca/technicalwriting/chapter/understandingteamdynamics/>

There is need for you to understand aspects of group dynamics such as group formation and management.

5.2 Lesson Outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

1. Identify barriers to effective team performance such as social loafing.
2. Discuss social loafing and its effects in groups.
3. Explain the importance of networking both in college and beyond

5.3 Group Formation and collaboration strategies

Groups go through different stages before they are able to begin working together effectively. Though these stages appear linear, in real life it is possible for a team to go back to an earlier stage depending on the prevailing situation. For example, they may move quite well performing stage and realize they have to retrace the steps to forming in order to gain clarity. See figure 6.1 and read the [Five models for understanding team dynamics](#) for more details.

Figure 5.3 Five models for understanding team dynamics



Source:

<https://pressbooks.bccampus.ca/technicalwriting/chapter/understandingteamdynamics/>

5.4 Cohesion and Collaboration strategies

You must have found that working in groups is not easy. Conflicts occur at various levels and if not properly handled, they can easily derail the group efforts. However, conflicts are not always negative.

One important element of becoming competent in interpersonal communication is honing the skills of **conflict resolution**. Overall, **effective communication** is at the core of every aspect of team operations: Empathic listening, and effective speaking and writing among others. You need also take into account other **soft skills like emotional intelligence**. Do you understand yourself? Can you handle your emotions effectively? Can you get into the shoes of other team members? These are among the questions you need to answer in order to contribute to effective teamwork. Refer to [Technical writing essentials](#) and [Team dynamics: Handling conflict](#) for more information.

E-tivity 5.4 Cohesion and collaborative strategies

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	5.4
Title	Cohesion and collaborative strategies
Purpose	This task will help you identify the role conflict resolution plays in cohesion and collaboration in teams.
Brief summary of overall task	Read Team dynamics: Handling conflict and Effective communication for effective conflict resolution . These will help you to answer the questions below.
Spark	 Source: Business conflict resolution

Individual task	1. Identify three advantages of conflict. 2. In two paragraphs, explain how avoidance as a conflict resolution strategy could affect your group performance.
Interaction begins	1. Post your answers in discussion forum 5.4. 2. Read one post from one other student and give constructive feedback.
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize the contributions. 2. Give feedback and learning points. 3. Close the e-tivity
Schedule and time	Spend 30 minutes on individual tasks and 30 minutes for the group tasks.
Next	Social loafing

5.5 Social loafing

A team, as we saw earlier, is an interdependent group working towards a common goal. There are times, however, when certain members of the group play the “passenger” role by exerting little effort towards the accomplishment of the group projects or tasks. This behavior can affect team performance in many ways. There are many reasons that lead to such behaviour. Let us examine some of these and the possible solutions in the following e-tivity.

E-tivity 5.5 Social loafing

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	5.5
Title	Social loafing

Purpose	The purpose of this e-tivity is to help you identify the reasons for social loafing in teams in order to use this knowledge to have effective and efficient teams.
Brief summary of overall task	Read the information the links provided and summarize the reasons for social loafing, and the effects on group members. https://courses.lumenlearning.com/msstate-waymaker-psychology/chapter/group-behavior/ https://en.wikibooks.org/wiki/Managing_Groups_and_Teams/Social_Loafing
Spark	 Source: Social loafing image
Individual task	1. Read the information in the links provided under summary and: a. List four reasons for social loafing in groups. b. Explain two effects of social loafing on the team members. c. List three solutions to social loafing in a group.

Interaction begins	1. If you noticed social loafers in your project group, what three solutions could you suggest to your team to address this issue? Post your contribution in discussion forum 5.5. Save a copy in your e-portfolio 2. Comment on the post of one of your colleagues and give positive and constructive feedback.
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize the contributions. 2. Give feedback and learning points. 3. Close the e-tivity
Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks.
Next	Networking skills

5.6 Networking skills

Networking is the process of building relationships with other people to help one another to achieve a certain goal. This happens mostly through information exchange. Networking is social capital that you can use to move from one level to a higher one. It is through networking that you are likely to meet the „Knowledgeable Other“ as [Vygotsky](#) puts it. This person can be your mentor or simply share information that you need in a particular aspect. In college, such a person could be a student from another year, your facilitator/lecturer, or even fellow students. It is important to build networks at every level of your life. These make it easy for you to link up with people who can help you accomplish goals easily.

E-tivity 5.6 Networking skills

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	5.6
Title	Networking skills
Purpose	The purpose of this e-tivity is to help you discuss the benefits of networking.
Brief summary of overall task	Read Theories of collaborative learning and Professional skills building & Networking to get more information about networking.

Spark	 Source: Professional skills building & Networking
Individual task	1. Read the sources under brief summary above. 2. Summarize the benefits of networking. 3. In one paragraph, explain how networking will help you in one area of your academic life.
Interaction begins	1. List three benefits of networking. 2. Read the answers of one other student in the class. 3. Give constructive feedback. 4. Post your answers in discussion forum5.6
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize the contributions. 2. Give feedback and learning points. 3. Close the e-tivity

Schedule and time	
---------------------------------	--

Next	
------	--

5.7 Assessment Questions

1. The stage of group formation where there is a likelihood of much conflict is:
 - a. Forming
 - b. Storming
 - c. Norming
 - d. Performing
2. The stages of group formation are linear. True/False
3. When a team member plays the „passenger“ role, this is referred to as -----
Loafing.
4. A well performing group will have g-a-s, -o-es, p-o-e--es, and interpersonal relationships to guide them.
5. Networking usually happens through-----exchange.

5.8 E-Resources

Group formation and collaborative strategies

1. Last, Susan & Neveu, Candice. (2019). Technical writing essentials: Introduction to professional communication in the technical fields.
<https://pressbooks.bccampus.ca/technicalwriting/chapter/understandingteamdynamics/>
2. Workgroups: Basic considerations
<https://opentextbc.ca/organizationalbehavioropenstax/chapter/work-groups-basic-considerations/#ch09rfin-1>

3. Managing effective work groups

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<https://opentextbc.ca/organizationalbehavioropenstax/chapter/managing-effective-work-groups/>

4. A primer o communication studies, 2012).

<https://2012books.lardbucket.org/books/a-primer-on-communication-studies/s06-02-conflict-and-interpersonal-com.html#>

5. Introduction to psychology: Group behavior

<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/msstate-waymaker-psychology/chapter/group-behavior/>

6. Managing groups and teams: Social loafing

https://en.wikibooks.org/wiki/Managing_Groups_and_Teams/Social_Loadng

7. Work groups: Basic considerations.

<https://opentextbc.ca/organizationalbehavioropenstax/chapter/work-groups-basic-considerations/#ch09rfin-1>

8. Professional skill building and networking

<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/suny-mcc-cos2master/chapter/networking/>

LESSON 6 INFORMATION LITERACY AND ETHICS

6.1 Introduction

Information literacy is crucial for effective and efficient functioning in all the areas of your life. This is more so in the 21st Century, which many refer to as the era of information and technology due to more reliance on knowledge than industrial economy. In the recent years, information and information sources have grown greatly and it is possible for you to feel quite overwhelmed as you try to access and use information for various academic and other purposes. In this lesson, we shall discuss ways of addressing this dilemma as we explore together information, information literacy, information sources, search strategies, and referencing techniques. These concepts are all important for your scholarly work at the university and beyond. The overall goal is to develop competences that form the

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basis for gaining control over how you interact with information in various contexts to serve different purposes.

6.2 Lesson Outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

- i. Explain the role of information literacy in your academic and other contexts.

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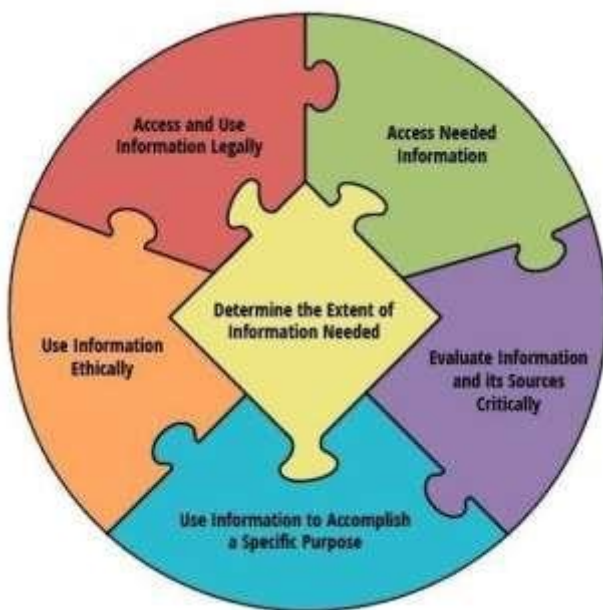
- ii. Explain the role of a university library.
- iii. Compare and contrast different information sources for tasks in various contexts.
- iv. Create a search strategy in order to locate and access appropriate information.
- v. Evaluate information sources.
- vi. Identify ethical issues related to your use of information from various sources.

6.3 Information Literacy

From the 1980s, a shift occurred that brought about the focus on information and information technology against the traditional Industrial Revolution, whose main concentration was on industries and production. More reliance on knowledge economy, therefore, has seen the explosion of information and the accompanying technological changes. You will find information in a variety of sources such as libraries, media, and the Internet. Moreover, it comes in many formats including graphics, audio, and text. To be able to navigate through this complex environment, therefore, it is important to acquire relevant skills.

According to the Association of College and Research Libraries (ACRL) (2000) information literacy is a set of abilities necessary for individuals in all disciplines, learning environments and levels of education. Currently, one needs the help of information technology to be able to carry out the activities that involve information. See Figure 5.3 for a summary of information literacy skills.

Figure 6.3



Source: Van Pelt, R., Opie, R. & Opie, J. (2020). Information Literacy

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<https://www.mtu.edu/library/instruction/information-literacy/>

E-tivity 6.3.2 Role of Information Literacy

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	6.3.2
Title	Information Literacy
Purpose	This activity will help you explain the role of information literacy in various contexts.
Brief summary of overall task	Watch this video , read the text and list the key competencies of an information literate person.

Spark	 Source: https://www.open.ac.uk/library/services/digital-and-information-literacy-for-students
Individual task	1. List the key competencies of an information literate person. 2. In a paragraph of not more than 300 words comment on how information literacy will increase your critical thinking skills in college. Post your answers in Assignment 6.3.
Interaction begins	1. In two sentences each, make constructive and positive comments on two posts from other class members. 2. Post your answer in discussion forum 6.3.
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize and weave the contributions. 2. Give feedback and learning points 3. Close the e-tivity a week from its commencement.

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Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks.
Next	Information search

6.4 Sources of Information

Since information is a vital commodity in any aspect of life, knowing how to find it, where to find it, and how to use it is important. There are many sources of information, which you can visit to meet your various academic and other needs. There is actually an explosion of information and information sources. Information and communication technology advancements have made information easily available. It is important, therefore, to learn

where to find information, how to find it efficiently and to gauge what best suits your specific needs.

Just as information sources are many so are the formats in which it is stored. The commonest is the book format .However; there are also many non-book formats. Non-book materials refer to materials that are not very dependent on the printed word to transmit data or information. Some of these also require some kind of equipment such as computers, projectors and others to transmit sounds, data, visual images contained in them. The following are some examples of categories of non-book materials:

- Cartographic materials such as maps and globes
- Music
- Sound recordings
- Motion pictures
- Electronic resources such as computer data or programs
- Three dimensional artefacts and realia
- Continuing resources: journals, newsletters, magazines, annual reports, etc.

E-tivity 6.4 Sources of information

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	6.4
Title	Sources of information
Purpose	This e-tivity will help you decide on the appropriate sources of information for a specific task.

SIR OTONDE -0741050074

Brief summary of overall task	Watch these two videos on Popular and scholarly sources: The information cycle, (2015) and Scholarly vs Popular periodicals (2007) . These will help you do the tasks below.
--------------------------------------	--

Spark	 The infographic displays six types of information sources, each with an icon and a brief description: Newspaper: A reporting and recording of cultural and political happenings that keeps the general public informed of daily events, sports, and current news. Opinions and public commentaries can also be included. Popular magazine: A glossy compilation of informative, entertaining stories with unique themes, intended for a specific interests—or lifestyles—from celebrities to gardening to gaming. Professional journal: A collection of work-related articles that keep professionals up-to-date on the latest trends, breakthroughs and controversies in their field. Scholarly journal: A collection of analytic reports that outline the objectives, background, methods, results, and limitations of new research written for and by scholars in a niche field. Reference book: A book in which the information presented is supported by clearly identified sources. Sometimes each chapter has a different author, and the editor puts them all together into a whole. Often these types of books have a narrow and specific focus. Encyclopedia: A book or set of books giving information on many subjects or on many aspects of one subject. Some are intended as an entry point into research; for a general audience, some provide detailed information. Must list relevant books and articles for further information on a topic.
Individual task	In a table, compare and contrast information from magazines and peer-reviewed journals as sources of information for your academic essays.
Interaction begins	1. Select two tables and provide positive and useful feedback to the owners. 2. Write your response in discussion forum 6.4
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize the contributions. 2. Give feedback and learning points. 3. Close the e-tivity
Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks.
Next	Developing a search strategy

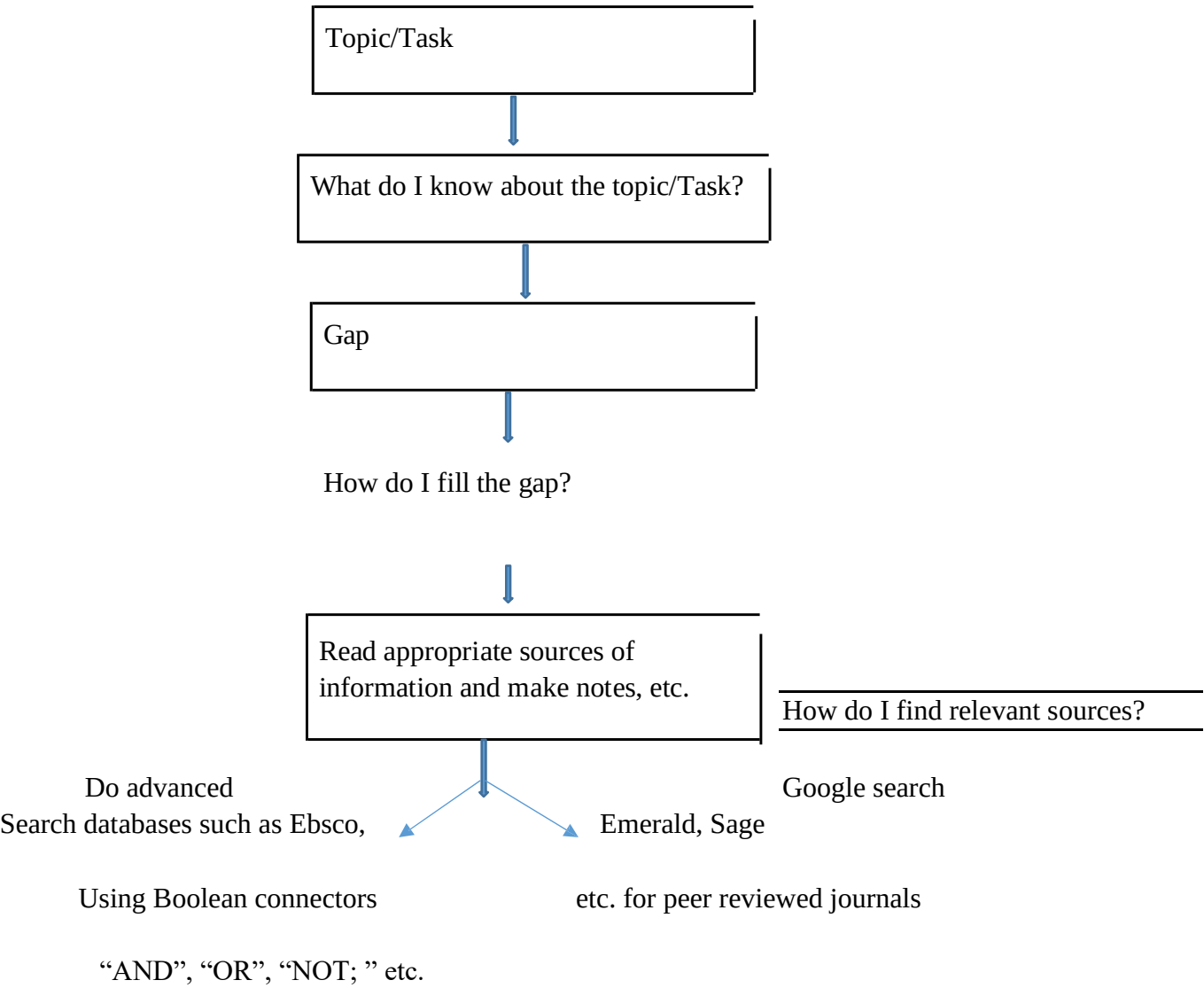
6.5 Developing a Search Strategy

A search strategy is your journey into finding information, which will address various needs. This could be academic, work related or an inquiry on any aspect of life. Let us take an example of an academic essay. You need to ask a number of questions about the process.

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What do I need? Where do I find it? How do I find it? See figure 5. For a summary of the process.

Figure 6.5 Summary of the search process



6.5.1 Advanced Search

Looking for sources online to address your information needs can be a daunting task. One way of getting more focused and useful results is by doing advanced search. For example, use Boolean Operators (AND or +, OR, and NOT). Read [Research process: Step by step](#) by University of Texas Libraries to get detailed information of how to do an advanced search.

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65.5.2 The Role of the University Library



Source: www.skyscrapercity.com

Source: www.ku.ac.ke

For many centuries, the university has been the main repository of information sources. Our commonest view of a library is a building with various sections that store information for different users. However, the university in the 21st Century does more than that. For example, it promotes information literacy in many ways. The focus is more on the user than storage of information. Remember, libraries are not always in buildings. For example, you can come across a [mobile vehicle libraries](#) or any other form. The libraries fall into different categories depending on users. The main ones are public, academic, national, academic, school, and special libraries.

6.5.3 Library Services

There are many services offered by the library staff. The library is divided according to subjects and other needs. There are subject specialists who will serve you at designated areas. Some of the services are lending, reservation, and inter library loan (ILL). ILL is based on the wider concept of library cooperation in which libraries agree to share resources. Books and journal articles that are unavailable in a particular library can be borrowed on behalf of the users from other libraries on interlibrary loan (ILL). When you click on the [library website](#), you will get to know about the services given to the users at the Kenyatta University Ultra-Modern Library.

6.5.4 Organization of Library Materials

Information is placed in categories to make it easier for users to access it. It is important that you understand how your library has organized information and where you can locate it. Familiarize yourself with the various elements of the library: the collections, locations, among others.

Another guide to finding information easily is the knowledge of the classification schemes. This is the arrangement of books and other reading material in the way that is most helpful

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to the users and librarians. This happens by grouping documents on the same subject together in one class.

There are several classification schemes, but most college, university and research libraries use the Library of Congress Classification scheme (LCC). This classification scheme derives its name from the Library of Congress for which it was devised. It consists of twenty-one classes (20 main and one general) represented by letters of the alphabet (A-Z). Each of the main classes is further divided into subclasses that represent disciplines (major branches) of the main class. This is done by introducing an additional letter to the main one. Read this document on [library classification systems](#) to learn more about classification systems.

6.5.4 The Library Catalogue

A catalogue is a list of available materials in a library arranged in some systematic manner, either physically or in electronic form. The arrangement facilitates the use of the collections; it also acts as a guide to the library's materials. The main uses of the catalogue, therefore, are to:

- Enable the user find a document of which either the author, the title or the subject is known.
- Show what resources a library has by a given author, subject, or format. A call number for each entry is also included.
- Show which editions of a particular work are in the library

6.5.5 Forms of Catalogues

Library catalogues are in different forms. Most libraries hold more than one form of catalogue. For many centuries, the physical card system dominated the libraries, but the Online Public Access Catalogue (OPAC) has overtaken this. Other kinds of catalogues include the book catalogue. Catalogues are arranged according to author, title, and subject in alphabetical order. Get further details on the [card catalogue](#) and here for more details on card catalogues and the OPAC by reading these resources.

E-tivity6.5.2 The role of the university library

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	6.5.2
Title	The role of the university library

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Purpose	The purpose of this activity is to help you reflect on the role of the university library in your academic and other aspects of life in the 21 st Century.
Brief summary of overall task	Click on the links below and summarize the role of the library in the 21 st century. 1. https://cutt.ly/TpVctpi 2. http://www.mjgds.org/library/library21-my-vision-for-a-21st-century-school-library/ 3. https://maktaba.ku.ac.ke/
Spark	<i>“When your average citizen thinks of a library they think of floors filled with shelves of books. How true is that statement today?”</i> Keith Webster

Individual task	Write a two-paragraph summary of the role of the university library in your academic and social life using the links in the summary of overall task.
Interaction begins	1. Write the two-paragraph summary in discussion forum 6.5.2. 2. Read the post by one of your group members and give positive and constructive feedback. 3. Post your reaction in Keep a copy in your group e-portfolio for easy access by the moderator/lecturer.
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize learners' responses on the task. 2. Provide direction as necessary 3. Close the e-tivity.
Schedule and time	1.5 hours for the individual task and 1 hour for the interaction (2.5 hours).
Next	Organization of library materials.

5.6 Evaluating Sources

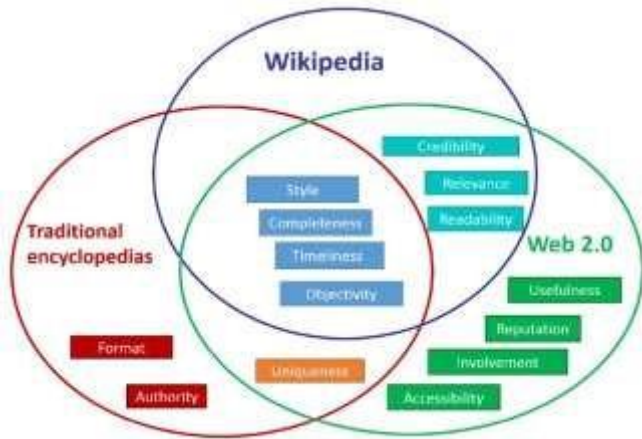
Remember, there is a lot of information on almost every subject you choose to work on. However, not all that information is reliable or will be able to meet your particular needs.

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Knowing how to select sources that meet your needs effectively and efficiently is a very important skill, which you need to develop for your academic, work and everyday life. Some of the elements to look for in a source are **accuracy**, **currency**, **authority**, **objectivity**, and **audience**.

E-tivity 6.6 Evaluating sources of information

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	6.6
---	-----

Title	Evaluating sources of information
Purpose	This e-tivity is to help you practice evaluating sources in order to access relevant information for your various tasks.
Brief summary of overall task	Read the information from the sources below and evaluate those sources for their appropriateness in addressing your specific task. 1. CABLE Source Credibility Downloadable Slides CABLES source evaluation form 2. Finding quality texts 3. Evaluating sources
Spark	 Source: Wikimedia Commons.
Individual task	In a table, compare and contrast information from magazines and peer-reviewed journals as sources of information for your academic essays in relation to author, audience, appearance, content, and references. Post your answer in discussion forum 5.6.3

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Interaction begins	1. Select two tables from your team members and give positive and constructive feedback. 2. Post the reaction in discussion forum 6.6.3.
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize learners' responses on the task. 2. Provide direction as necessary 3. Close the e-tivity a week from the commencement date.
Schedule and time	1.5 hours for the individual task and 1 hour for the interaction (2.5 hours).
Next	Information ethics

6.7 Information Ethics

The Institute of Global Ethics (2016) defines information ethics as “*the branch of ethics that focuses on the relationship between the creation, organization, dissemination, and use of information, and ethical standards, and moral codes governing human conduct in society.*”

Information ethics is a broad area that cuts across disciplines and practices. For example, here we discuss information ethics mainly in the context of use of information for academic purposes such as writing papers. We shall also try to relate it to a wider application in everyday life.

One of the indicators for an information literate person is the ability to use information effectively and in an ethical manner. One of the major ethical breaches in information use is plagiarism, whose common signs are:

- A. Not giving credit to the author(s) for information borrowed while writing academic papers.
- B. Cut and paste large chunks of information
- C. Not observing copyright and fair use laws.
- D. Submitting an assignment that is substantially, or entirely, the work of another student with or without the students' knowledge

Some of the penalties of plagiarism are low grades, a fail, or discontinuation from a course altogether. You need to avoid the actions listed in A-D as you use information in your academic, work, or other aspects of life.

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You can avoid plagiarism in many ways, such as addressing the unethical issues we raised earlier on. Let us look at problem A, giving credit to the author for the information you use in creating your essay, speech presentation, or any other task.

E-tivity 6.7

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	6.7
Title	Information ethics
Purpose	The purpose of this e-tivity is to help you analyze unethical use of information.
Brief summary of overall task	Discuss how to address these unethical practices in writing academic papers. A. Not giving credit to the author(s) for information borrowed while writing academic papers. B. Cut and paste large chunks of information

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BY SIR OTONDE -0741050074

64

6.7.1 Referencing Techniques

Academic writing at this level requires that you rely on other people's ideas to develop your arguments and other forms of writing. You need to go beyond stating facts and opinions or showing what you know about a subject by backing up all you write by credible research or other information from experts in your field of study. This is done through various ways such as summarizing, paraphrasing, direct quotations within the text (i.e. do in-text citation/parenthetical references) or at the bottom of the text (footnoting), and at the end of the text in a bibliography or reference list to avoid being accused of **plagiarism**. There are many technique/styles, such as the American Psychological Association (APA), and the Modern Language Association (MLA), which guide you on how to do this.

Find out the referencing style used by your school or organization and familiarize yourself with it. Remember to use whatever style you choose, or is recommended, consistently within the text, when preparing your bibliography or reference list, and in formatting the text. Click [here](#) and [here](#) for examples of how to acknowledge sources of information within the essay and to prepare the lists using APA.

6.7.2 Footnotes

These are often explanatory notes given either at the bottom of the page on which they appear or listed at the end of a chapter as endnotes (List of references). They indicate the authority cited or some technical terms that need explanation. They are useful in authenticating writer's statements and giving guidance for further reading. They also indicate what was directly quoted by the writer in amplifying some points in the

SIR OTONDE-0741050074

discussion of the central theme. However, the footnoting technique is very rarely used in APA unless when deemed necessary to give details on content and copyright.

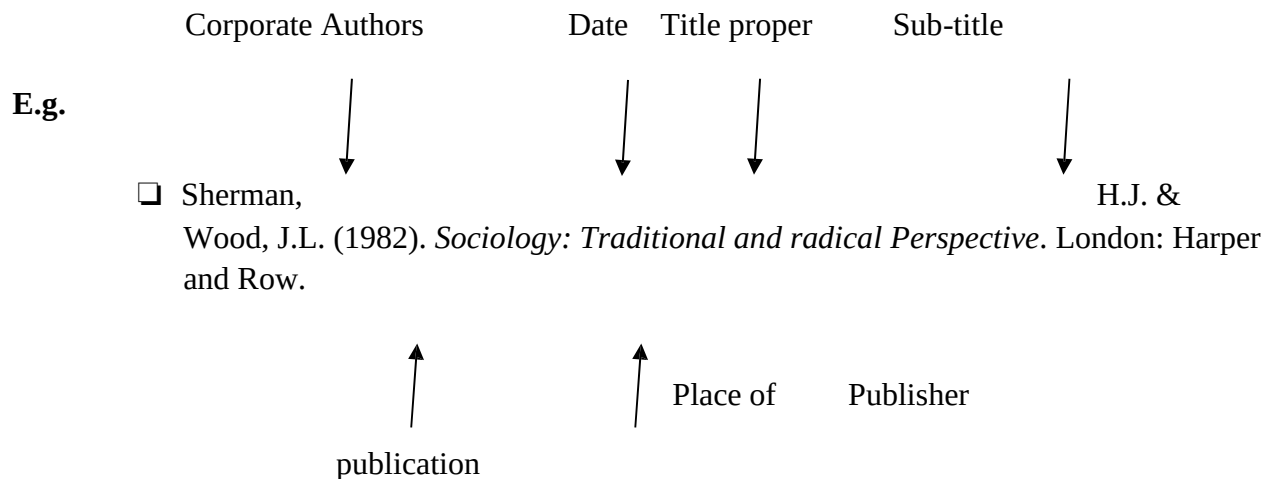
6.7.3 Preparing a Bibliography

Bibliography is a list of resources used in writing an essay, whether directly referred to (in the text either in parenthetical references or in footnotes) or simply used indirectly in forming the argument. Note, however, that different styles have their specifications and even names for these lists. For example, the American Psychological Association (APA) uses "reference list"

instead of “bibliography”. Generally, a reference list is used when you include only those sources that you have referred to directly in the essay.

6.7.4 Contents of a Reference

The main title is referred to as the **title proper**. Some publications have a **subtitle**, which is a descriptive phrase that clarifies or explains the title proper. This helps to make a particular book or publication easily identifiable.



Note: Where a referencing style requires that you underline a title, underline both the title proper and the subtitle as if they were one.

E.g.

- Sherman, H.J. & Wood, J.L. (1982). Sociology: Traditional and radical Perspective. London: Harper and Row.

- **Parallel title**

A parallel title is the title given in a publication, but in another language or script other than that used in the text. Parallel titles are separated by the = sign.

E.g.

- Kingala, Y.M. (1985). *Nguzo za Kiswahili: Darasa la 8 = Foundation for Kiswahili : Standard 8*. Nairobi: Phoenix.

Note: If you were to underline these titles, you do so as if they were one.

E.g. Kingala, Y.M. (1985). Nguzo za Kiswahili: Darasa la 8 = Foundation for Kiswahili: Standard 8. Nairobi: Phoenix.

Another thing to note is that the bibliographic details of a published book will be slightly different from those of a journal article, a book chapter, and many other sources.

E-tivity 6.7.3 Preparing a bibliography

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	6.7.3
Title	Preparing a bibliography
Purpose	The purpose of this e-tivity is to help you analyze references using the American Psychological Association format PA style.
Brief summary of overall task	Read the references and arrange their bibliographic information using the APA style 7th edition .

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Spark	1. (IJER)Catherine Gakii Murungi, 2013, Reasons for Low Enrolments in Early Childhood Education in Kenya: The parental perspective. International Journal of Education and Research , Vol. 1 No. 5, May 2013, pp. 1-10 2. Nyerere, J. K. A. & Friso, V. 2013. Journal of Training and Development.37(7):662-677, Forums for Dialogue between University and Industry: A case of Kenyatta University, Kenya and University of Padua, Italy 3. A. M. Karugu (2014), Rights of Children in the Kenyan Primary School Curriculum, Msingi Journal Vol. 1 No. 1 2014, pp. 236 – 260, Nairobi CUEA Press 4. Designing brain-compatible learning (3rd ed.). Thousand Oaks, CA: Corwin, (2006), Gregory, G., & Parry, T.
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BY SIR OTNDE

Individual task	In a table, arrange the references above using the APA. Save your answer in a portfolio that can be easily accessed by the e-moderator/lecturer.
Interaction begins	1. Post your answer in discussion forum 6.7.3. 2. Comment on one other student's table.
E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize learners' responses on the task. 2. Give feedback on learning points and provide direction as necessary 3. Close the e-tivity.
Schedule and time	The task should take one hour to complete.
Next	Citation/Bibliography management tools.

6.7.5 Citation/Bibliography Management Tools

There are many programs designed to help writers, including you, prepare their bibliography or reference lists with ease. They require that you download and install them into your computer. It is important, however, to note that these programs fall into various categories:

- Free
- Partially free
- Not free so need purchasing

Go for a program that is convenient for you. In case you need to use any of the tools, get help from the university librarians. Check out for alerts for training posted regularly on the library website. You will get help particularly with Mendely. Read the [Citation management tools: Overview](#) document for more details.

6.7.5 Plagiarism Checker

Many applications help in detecting levels of plagiarism in texts. Some examples are [Grammarly](#) and [Tutnitin](#). The university librarians will give you guidance on plagiarism checkers.

6.8 Assessment Questions

1. One of the reasons information literacy is important in the 21st century is ----- overload.
2. According to Van Pelt, Opie & Opie (2020), an information literate person should be able to:
 - a. -----
 - b. -----
 - c. -----
 - d. -----
 - e. -----
 - f. -----
3. A----- has to be included in order to make a particular book or publication easily identifiable.
 - a. Heading
 - b. Subtitle
 - c. Main title

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4. We evaluate sources of information to test them for ac-u-a-y, c- r-e-cy, o-j-c-i--ty, and authority, among other qualities.

6.9 E-References

General

1. ACRL Information literacy competency standards for higher education.pdf
<https://lair.ala.org>
2. Presidential committee on information literacy: Final report.
<http://www.ala.org/acrl/publications/whitepapers/presidential>
3. Macefield, R. (2009). Encyclopedia of information communication technology.
<https://www.igi-global.com/chapter/ict-literacy-information-age/13382>
3. The official guide to library resources for your English Composition papers
<https://libguides.mnsu.edu/c.php?g=4022&p=14263>
4. Using footnotes(APA) <https://writingcommons.org/article/using-footnotes-apa/>

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Information sources

- 1, Types of information: Examples of information sources
<https://libguides.astate.edu/c.php?g=14512&p=78160>
2. Vincent Library video on Scholarly and Popular Sources. Carnegie
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tN8S4CbzGXU>
3. Information sources types
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PDmQ5QoIaGQ>
- 4 Examples of information sources
<https://libguides.astate.edu/c.php?g=14512&p=78160>
5. Library research: An introduction
<https://library.triton.edu/research>
6. Library research: An introduction

<https://library.triton.edu/research>

7. **Research process: Types of sources**

<https://libguides.uaptc.edu/c.php?g=600685&p=4159599>

8. **Evaluating sources of information**

<https://openoregon.pressbooks.pub/technicalwriting/chapter/4-5-search-strategies/>;

Information Ethics

1. Mason, R. O. Four ethical issues of the information age.

<https://www.gdrc.org/info-design/4-ethics.html>

2. **First year seminar readings: Ethical use of information**

<https://psufys.pressbooks.com/chapter/ethical-use-of-information/>

3. The information literacy user's guide: An open, online textbook. Allison Hosier et.al. 2014, April.

<http://www.oercommons.org/courses/the-information-literacy-user-s-guide-an-open-online-textbook-2/view>

4. **Purdue Online Writing Lab**

<https://owl.english.purdue.edu/owl/resource/560/05/>

Doing a Library Search

1. Library research: An introduction

<https://library.triton.edu/research>

2. Search strategies.

<https://openoregon.pressbooks.pub/technicalwriting/chapter/4-5-search-strategies/>

3. How library stuff work: Boolean operators.

<https://libguides.uta.edu/researchprocess/strategy>

4. Search Smart-Truncation, Wildcat and Phrase Searching.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?time_continue=82&v=DsypxBNUyMo&feature=emb_title)

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5. How do I search effectively?

<https://libguides.exeter.ac.uk/c.php?g=664993&p=4706849>

6. <https://writingcenter.tamu.edu/Students/Writing-Speaking-Guides/Alphabetical-List-of-Guides/Citing-Documenting/Evaluating-Scholarly-Sources>

7. Gavin, P. (1985). OPAC: ONLINE PUBLIC ACCESS CATALOGUE.

https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-94-009-5452-6_18

Evaluating Sources of information Evaluating

scholarly sources.

<https://libguides.exeter.ac.uk/c.php?g=664993&p=4706849>

Checking for plagiarism

1. <http://elearningindustry.com/12-best-free-online-bibliography-and-citation-tools>

2. <https://www.mendeley.com/>

3. <https://www.zotero.org/>

Citation styles

1. **APA 7th edition: Citation**

<https://libguides.csudh.edu/citation/apa-7>

2. APA citation style, 7th edition: General style guidelines

<https://guides.himmelfarb.gwu.edu/c.php?g=27779&p=170331>

Managing the bibliography/Reference list

Citation management tools: An overview

<https://findlay.libguides.com/citationmanagment>

B
F

LESSON 7: READING SKILLS

7.1 Introduction

Life in the age when so much information is available requires individuals to possess the ability to read and process efficiently large amounts of information on a daily basis to meet a variety of needs. The ability to read and respond appropriately to academic information, at work and in other personal contexts is an important prerequisite for living successful and fulfilled lives in the 21st century. In the current society, new information is being created and disseminated at a rate never witnessed before in history. To succeed academically and in other aspects of life, one can only ignore such information at his/her peril. Therefore, the ability to read effectively and efficiently and to keep abreast with information is key. To be adaptable and to cope with change in a complex, fast changing, and globalizing world requires that one is constantly reading. This lesson will discuss reading as an active process of meaning creation, purposes for reading, styles of reading and reading techniques, note making and transcoding of graphs and tables.

7.2 Lesson Learning Outcomes

- i. By the end of this lesson you will be able to:
- ii. Explain reading as an active process of creating meaning using examples from both academic and non- academic materials.
- iii. Identify purposes for reading using texts from academic and other contexts.
- iv. Discuss various reading styles and techniques.
- v. Make notes using different note formats.
- vi. Transcode graphs and tables.

7.2.1 Definition of reading

In the past, reading has been viewed as a linear process of looking at and understanding the written word. Today, reading is seen to be an active as well as interactive process and readers are engaged both mentally, intellectually, emotionally as well as physically. Reading is not just a personal process. Readers often interact with others in order to enhance understanding or apply new gained information. In the course of your studies, these and many other types of

engagement will be expected, many of which will be performed in activities where the learner is attempting to put to use or to apply information gained from existing background knowledge and the current reading itself. You should notice how you interact with the author by using information that you already know in reading. You think, ask questions and challenge the author's point of view not just on the basis of what is on the page but also what is in your mind from previous reading, listening and practical experiences. Reading, as you will discover, is strongly linked to your listening, speaking and writing skills. These skills can be applied before, during and after the reading of a text. This broad understanding of reading is important and forms a proper background for what follows in the rest of this lesson.

7.2.2 Purpose for Reading

Having a definite reading purpose helps in better understanding. There are three broad reasons or purposes for reading. These are academic or learning, functional and entertainment. In academic contexts, the range of material that we read is wide and covers academic textbooks, journal articles, conference proceedings, thesis, and other unpublished material such as newspapers and magazines. Functional purposes include reading various documents in work and personal contexts. Popular magazines and novels form materials for leisure reading. When we read for academic purposes, there are varied reasons. Consider purposes such as reading the following:

- lecture notes in order to prepare for a test or examination
- different sources of information to make notes for use in writing an essay on emotional intelligence
- a given topic to follow an argument for or against human cloning
- a chapter in order to understand the process of human cloning
- a graph to study the trend in urban growth and settlement in African cities
- a definition to better understand the meaning of homeostasis

What we have here is only a very small list of reasons why we read as learners. The idea is that you should be specific with your purpose. You can think of many more reasons. Think of these in terms of cause and effect, definition, comparison and contrast, description, classification, evidence to support a case and so on. Another way of identifying a reading purpose is asking the questions what, why, when, who, how about a given topic.

7.2.3 Styles of Reading

The way you read a text is what we refer to here as the style of reading. The style of reading is determined by two things namely; the purpose for your reading and secondly the nature of the material being read. One cannot separate styles of reading and reading purpose because they

go hand in hand. If I am reading in order to defend a particular point of view, I will not read in the same way if I was reading to pass time while waiting for the bus. The following are common ways of reading:

- Skimming,
- Scanning,
- Comprehension,
- Critical reading
- Word for word reading
- Light reading

Skimming and scanning are both referred to as anti-reading techniques because much of the written text is skipped. In skimming, the reader is looking for the gist or the main point or theme of a given text and is less interested in most of the minute details such as examples, descriptions, explanations and narratives. In scanning, the purpose is to look for specific information such a definition of a concept, some specific explanation, and name of a person or place, a formula or an important historical date. A lot of text is skipped in so doing. Comprehension aims at understanding the material but critical reading requires the reader to evaluate or analyze the material. Critical reading requires a thorough appraisal of the views of an author, which may be compared to the views of other authors who have written on the same issue or topic. Word for word reading is applied where material is difficult or one is learning a foreign language and light reading is mainly a leisure way of reading where it is not important to remember information.

When we talk of reading styles, we cannot ignore the term strategies or techniques. There are different strategies of reading. Many of them are presented as reading formulas. You are familiar with these formulas, the oldest of which is the SQ3R formula. Reading formulas are widely acclaimed for their success in supporting reading and especially in aiding memorization. You may want to do your own research of the SQ3R and other formulas and how best to apply them for effective reading.

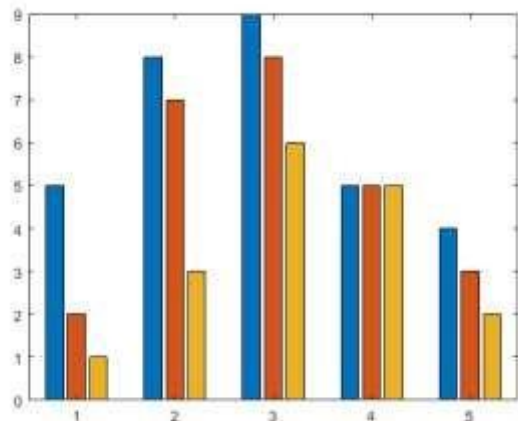
There are other reading techniques where the reader makes use of their background knowledge and linguistic and non-linguistic clues for better understanding. Searching your mind for information you already have is useful. Just one little idea in your mind can be useful in trying to interpret a non-familiar text. You move from known to unknown and language clues such as references and transition signals help a lot. Being able to predict what a text is about based on the title is also a reading technique.

7.2.4 Reading and Note Making Formats

There are many ways of making notes from textbooks and other reading materials. We distinguish between formal and informal note making formats. You will come across terms as

point note format, sentence note formats, outline notes, standard notes, flow chart method, tree diagram, mind maps and the Cornell format. The terms linear and patterned notes are also used. The idea is that there is a lot of flexibility when it comes to note making. The main goal of note making is to select and organize key points and the main details in a manner that makes sense for further study or use.

E-tivity 7.2.4 Note- Making Formats

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	7.2.4																								
Title	Note Making Formats																								
Purpose	The purpose of this topic is to get you to find out more on what note-making formats will be most applicable as you navigate different academic and non-academic material and as you listen to lectures and in other contexts.																								
Brief summary of overall task	Carry out a google search on note making formats and summarize the key features of both linear and patterned (non-linear) note formats.																								
Spark	 <table><caption>Data for Spark Bar Chart</caption><thead><tr><th>Group</th><th>Blue Bar</th><th>Orange Bar</th><th>Yellow Bar</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>1</td><td>5</td><td>2</td><td>1</td></tr><tr><td>2</td><td>8</td><td>7</td><td>3</td></tr><tr><td>3</td><td>9</td><td>8</td><td>6</td></tr><tr><td>4</td><td>5</td><td>5</td><td>5</td></tr><tr><td>5</td><td>4</td><td>3</td><td>2</td></tr></tbody></table>	Group	Blue Bar	Orange Bar	Yellow Bar	1	5	2	1	2	8	7	3	3	9	8	6	4	5	5	5	5	4	3	2
Group	Blue Bar	Orange Bar	Yellow Bar																						
1	5	2	1																						
2	8	7	3																						
3	9	8	6																						
4	5	5	5																						
5	4	3	2																						
Individual task	1. Carry out an internet study of the top three note-making formats. 2. Make brief notes under each of the three formats listing advantages and disadvantages. Base your answer on your project topic.																								

Interaction begins	1. In your project groups brainstorm what you understand by the following statement: “At the heart of each note- making activity is an attempt to structure and remember information”. Use the information from your individual task above to guide the session. 2. In two sentences each, comment on the contributions of two other groups. Post your answers in the discussion forum 7.4.3.
E-moderator interventions	I will: 1. Summarize learners’ responses on task. 2. Provide direction as necessary 3. Close the e-tivity a week from the commencement date.
Schedule and time	Spend 1 hour on individual tasks and 1 hour for the group tasks.
Next	Transcoding of Graphs and Tables

7.2.5 Transcoding of Graphs, Tables and Charts

Graphs, tables and charts are common visual aids in academic texts and are used extensively in research communication contexts such as conferences where presenters use Power Point slides. Writers and conference presenters use them to help their readers understand complex data. Outside the academic world, these images have wide application and they form a big part in annual reports of financial organizations, government and non-government organizations. Tables, graphs and charts arrest the attention of the reader and they make the information communicated more interesting. Information on health, food expenditure, imports and exports can be conveyed easily in graphic form. Variables measured include quantities in litres or tons, percentages or numbers. Time variables are also presented in months or years. Of key interest to writers is to present a trend by showing how data changes over a given period in that it may increase or fall, fluctuate or remain stable.

E-tivity 7.2.5- Transcoding Tables and Graphs

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Numbering, pacing and sequencing	7.2.5
Title	Transcoding Graphs and Tables
Purpose	In this e-tivity, we look at images in graphical, tabular and chart formats in order to appreciate the importance of visual aids in the interpretation of academic and non-academic information.
Brief summary of overall task	Learner will study various graphs (www.google.com/search/graphs) and make a list of five variables measured in the visual aids.
Spark	Heading 1. Subheading 1.1. Point 1.2. Point 1.3. Point 1.3.1. Sub-point 1.3.2. Sub-point 2. Subheading 2.1. Point 2.2. Point 3. Subheading 3.1. Point 3.2. Point
Individual task	1. Using data from three graphs on health, list the three topics covered by the three graphs. 2. Using the same graphs, summarize in two sentences the key impression conveyed by each graph. 3. Write your answers in assignment 7.2.5
Interaction begins	1. Comment on the topics from the responses of two other groups. Use a maximum of two sentences per comment. 2. Post the responses in the discussion forum 4.3.5.

E-moderator interventions	Ensure learners correctly interpret task and remain focused Provide feedback on learner progress with tasks. Close the e-tivity at the end of the 10 days.
Schedule and time	Individual activities to take 2 hours. Group activity to take 2 hours
Next	Assessment questions

7.3 Assessment questions

1. In reading, meaning usually lies on the written page and the reader has to pick it. True/False
2. Linear note format is applicable in science study only. True/ False
3. Skimming is used in reading newspapers only. True/False
4. A variable is a measure that has a tendency to change with time. True/False
5. Not every type of information can be presented in graph form. True/ False

7.4 E-references

1. [Developing searching, skimming, and scanning skills with Internet Bingo](#)
2. [Mind pictures: Strategies that enhance mental imagery while reading](#)
3. [Reading strategy: Determining a purpose for reading](#)
4. [Critical reading skills for the 21st century: The role of universities](#)
5. [How to learn like a pro](#)

LESSON 8.0 ADVANCED WRITING SKILLS

8.1 Introduction

Academic essay writing is fundamentally a thinking process. For example, it involves such stages as interpreting a topic, discriminating between relevant and irrelevant ideas, differentiating key ideas from less important ones, evaluating the views of other writers, arguing logically, selecting relevant evidence, drawing valid conclusions from given data as well as summarizing and paraphrasing among others. Remember also that your writing is a mirror of your reading habits.

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Writing is a very practical skill. Remember that your success as a student will be assessed mainly through your writing. Consider what Thornton (1980:17) has said: “*The mastery of the writing system is the greatest gift that schools [universities] can bestow on those who pass through them...because it is upon [their]ability to write that judgments with the most important consequences are made.*”

In this topic, we cover various aspects of writing such as writing in academic and non-academic contexts, features of academic writing, argumentation, acknowledging sources of information and collaborative research and writing skills.

8.2 Lesson Outcomes.

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

1. Explain the main features of academic writing.
 2. Do collaborative research and select an essay topic on a given genre.
 3. Collaboratively plan for the essay.
 4. Write the essay in the given genre.
- 6 Use a recommended referencing style to acknowledge sources of information and prepare a reference list/bibliography.

8.3 Writing in academic and non- academic contexts.

There are many kinds of genres produced by different writers to address various needs. Consider for example, a letter to a friend, memoranda, newspapers, novels, business writing and the like. Each type of writing is different from others in relation to the style, the vocabulary, purpose and the reader it is meant for. Academic writing is writing among university professors and their students. It is serious writing, guided by certain conventions or rules such that you do not have the freedom to present your ideas in any way you like or are comfortable with.

8.3.1 Uses of Academic Writing

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Writing is a way of thinking about a subject. When you write essays on any given topic, you are doing several things to help you master the subject, understand your academic community, and many more. The following are some of the reasons Budd (2005, p.3) gives for writing essays at this level:

- they make you think about an issue in depth;
- they help you develop the ability to think logically, to argue a case;
- they make you relate theoretical knowledge to particular issues;
- they help you to write cogently and fluently;
- they help you to write according to the demands of a particular discipline....

8.3.2 Features of Academic Writing.

As we have said earlier, academic writing is peculiar and is identified by certain characteristics. For example:

- Writers usually avoid the use of personal pronouns, I, you, he, me, she, him, and so rely more on the passive as opposed to the active voice.

❑ Examples

Passive voice

The examination results are amazing.

The operation on the young girl was completed in two hours.

Active Voice

I am amazed by the examination results.

It took me two hours to operate on the young girl.
I took two hours to operate on the young girl.

- It avoids contractions such as “can’t”, “don’t”, “won’t”, “shouldn’t”, etc. or clichés, slang, colloquialism. These are expressions such as “The poor folks” “the kids”, etc. “kudos to our dear country”, “too many idlers”.
- It is aimed at other academics. The academic audience is usually regarded as skeptical: one that is hard to convince or one that does not accept other people's ideas without seriously considering their intellectual value. It means then as a writer for this audience, you have to take extra caution in order to present information in a manner that will win approval from your audience.
- It is a lengthy as well as creative process involving various stages such as choosing a topic, focusing the topic, gathering ideas, determining a structure , drawing an outline, drafting, revising, editing and proof-reading.

8.3.3 The Stages of the academic writing Process

Writing can be described as a process of discovering ideas, developing and organizing them. The process is not simple, and neither does it take place in a linear manner. It is, therefore, dynamic and recursive. Good writing takes a lot of time and practice.

Every successful journey starts with a good plan and so is your writing project. Before you set out to write, make sure you have a roadmap for the different stages of the project and specific dates for every activity.

No two people write in the same way. Some outline ideas before writing about them, while others do not. Some write their introduction first, while others do it at the end. Some revise their essay as they go along; some do it at a later point. Not all writers follow the same method, and different writers use different methods in writing for different purposes. As a student writer, you must discover the approach that works best for you on any particular occasion.

Still, most experienced writers have reported that to produce a good piece of writing, you have to pass through certain stages while writing an essay. Note, however, that there is also no concrete agreement on the names of these stages. One example is:

- Exploring and planning: discovering a topic, focusing, finding support details and organizing ideas.
- Drafting: getting ideas and supporting details down on paper in rough form.
- Revising: rethinking and rewriting drafts to improve content, focus and structure and the general flow of ideas.
- Editing and proofreading: checking for effective word choice and sentence structure, correct grammar, spelling, punctuation and mechanics.

E-tivity 8.3.2 &8.3.3 Features of academic writing and the writing process

Numbering spacing and sequencing	8.3.2 and 8.3.3
Title	Features of academic writing and the stages of the academic writing process.

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Purpose	1. This is to let you identify and use features of academic writing 2. To practice the stages of the academic writing process.
Brief summary of overall task	Read Features of academic writing and Academic writing . 1. Features of academic writing. 2. The stages in the writing process.
Spark	1. What does academic writing mean to you? 2. What stages do you go through when writing your academic essays?
Individual task	1. In point form, write five features of academic writing. 2. In two sentences, enumerate the stages of academic writing.
	3. Post your answers on the forum.
Interaction begins	Read answers from two students and provide constructive feedback. Post your work in discussion forum 8.3.2 and 8.3.3 .
Schedule and time	The e-tivity should take two hours.
Next	Understanding essay questions.

8.4 Understanding Essay Topics

Although as a student, you may be given freedom to think of your own topic to write an essay on, many times you will find that your course instructor will ask you to write

on prescribed topics. The ability to understand your essay topic well is an important step in all types of essay writing. If you are going to write a good essay, you must begin by taking a careful look at the topic in order to make correct judgment as to what exactly your instructor requires of you. To do this, you need to be aware that essay topics are usually presented in two forms: open-ended or closed essay topics.

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8.4.1 Open-Ended Topics

Such topics give a lot of freedom to you as a writer. How you respond to the topic is usually a matter of your own creativity and imagination. Consider the following.

1. Causes of amnesia.
2. “People are what they eat.” Discuss.
3. It is better to live a single life than to marry.
4. “A human being’s chief business on earth is to communicate.” Discuss.
5. “You don’t need a college degree today to be successful in life.” Discuss.
6. “Thinking being: unique being.” Discuss

8.4.2 Closed Topics.

Closed topics are more specific and often set a limit as to what you should say or do as a writer. Look at the following examples:

1. Identify three major environmental problems facing Kenya today. Explain their nature. Say which is the most serious and why.
2. Using any relevant model of communication identify and explain five essential elements of the communication process.
3. Discuss the role of women in environmental conservation in a country of your choice.

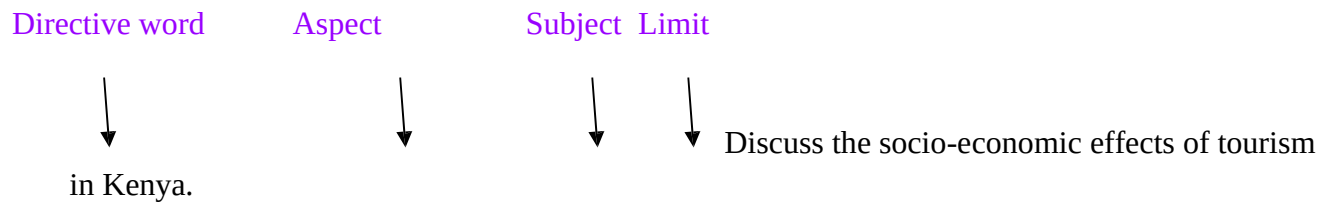
8.4.3 Parts of an Essay Topic

In order to decide accurately the kind of ideas, information, explanations, or facts to include in your essay, you need to identify the following from your topic be it a closed or open-ended one:

- Directive/instructional verbs (E.g. Describe, analyze, discuss, compare and contrast, etc.)
- Content words/Subject (E.g. Tourism, culture, environment, etc.).
- Aspect (Usually signaled by a phrase ending in „of“ e.g. economic effects of)
- Scope/limit/extent ((E.g. “three”, “four”, “never”, “always”, “in 1000 words”, “facing”, “before”, “ during”, “between 1800 and 1960”, “greatest impact”, etc.

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E.g.



8.5 Planning the Essay

In order to create strong, clear and logically structured paragraphs, you are advised to first prepare an outline or plan which will serve as a tool for ordering ideas in your essay. The important thing to note is that plans or outlines will differ from writer to writer although at the centre each planning activity is the need to structure ideas for the essay in a suitable, logical manner.

Planning is a very important stage in writing an academic essay. It is a mental activity and must be differentiated from a „plan“ or „outline“, which is a physical or written product of the mental activity. As a process, planning begins when you start analyzing your essay topic. It continues as you gather information and make notes, as you formulate a tentative structure in which you will organize your ideas and does not end until you complete the essay. Planning integrates very closely with all your writing activities. It does not progress linearly but is a rather recursive process – meaning that as a writer you are not a slave to your plan. You produce a plan to use as a tool for writing and you can change or alter sections of it as you continue to discover more information about your subject.

There is not one way of planning. At the center of each planning process, however, is the need to look for a suitable structure in which to order or organize information. How you order the material itself as well as your purpose in writing the essay will determine information. Whereas some essay topics have an inherent structure, others will require that you seriously consider which the best mode of presenting your ideas is. In writing an essay that describes a process, you cannot, for example impose your own order. In an argument, however, you will order your points of view and other evidence in the manner you feel will be most convincing to the reader. For example, you may choose order of most to least important or least important to most important. You could use a different order altogether.

To arrive at a useful plan, consider the following planning strategies:

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- Analyze your essay topic.
- Go over all the information you have collected i.e. your notes.
- Identify all key points.
- Think about an approximate sequence for your material.
- Draw up a tentative plan or outline.

Outlining can be done manually or using computer software such as Omnioutliner, Inspiration

8.6 Gathering Information

Once you have a topic, you will need supporting material such as facts, ideas, examples, observations, memories, views from experts, and stories. If you are writing on a familiar topic, you can use your original material to support the ideas. This you can do using a technique known as brainstorming. However, it is rare that you will be able to produce a forceful, vivid, interesting academic essay by drawing upon only what is in your head. When your topic is unfamiliar, talking with people who are knowledgeable on the topic can also produce useful results. One of the things you will notice is that brainstorming alone cannot yield adequate information for a scholarly essay. You need to read widely.

8.6.1 Reading and Note-Making

Reading is the best way for you to grapple with an unfamiliar topic. Your course facilitators will usually give you a reading or reference list. However, even if such help is not there, it is important that you search the university E-catalogue or Online Public Access Catalog (OPAC) and other resources for useful sources of information. Look through each to find and jot down any information that looks useful, as direct quotations, either paraphrases or summaries. Whenever you use a direct quotation or you paraphrase or summarize material from a source, you must give proper credit to the source. This means that your notes and finally the essay should show that the ideas you have used are not simply yours but also from authorities in the field under investigation. After all, that is what academic writing at this level is all about; it is associated with other authors. See [quoting, summarizing, and paraphrasing](#) for details. Ensure that you keep a clear record of what you have read for ease in drafting your essay and preparing your reference list/bibliography.

E-tivity 8.4

Numbering spacing and sequencing	8.4, 8.5, 8.6
Title	Understanding essay topics & Planning and gathering information.

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Purpose	These e-tivities will enable you to formulate clear essay topics, plan an essay and gather content for your academic essays.
Brief summary of overall task	http://www2.le.ac.uk/offices/ld/resources/dept/crim/planning-essa http://www2.le.ac.uk/offices/ld/resources/dept/fpsyc/copy_of_writing-essays Read the information on above links and carry out the tasks below.
Spark	1. Do you understand essay topics before you begin to write? 2. Think of ways of getting information also how you plan the content.
Individual task	<u>“Challenges of the boy child.”</u> 1. Improve on this topic by providing directive verbs. 2. Find and write down the relevant sources of the content for your improved topic. Post these on your group’s e-portfolio.
Interactions begins	-Compare your answers in the group and provide feedback.
E-moderator interventions	-Ensure that the learners carry out the e-tivity - Give feedback that will enhance learning.
Schedule and time	This should take two hours.
Next	Developing effective paragraphs.

8.7 Sections of the essay and Developing Effective Paragraphs

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An academic essay has three main subdivisions: the introduction, the body, and the conclusion. Each one of these contains main ideas and supporting details, all developed using paragraphs.

8.7.1 Introduction

The introduction plays a very important role in your academic essay. It is usually written mainly in order to announce to your reader your main intention or purpose for writing the essay. As academic essays are written in order to inform or to persuade an audience, therefore, your introduction should aim at making you are the reader to be interested in reading the essay. The most important sentence in the introduction is the [thesis statement](#) or your statement of intention. It is this sentence more than any other that determines what you will say in the rest of the essay. It is usually referred to as the controlling sentence of the entire essay. It is usually the last sentence in the introduction and it establishes a smooth link between the introduction and the body.

E-tivity 8.5

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	8.5.0
Title	Developing Effective Paragraphs
Purpose	This e-tivity will enable you to acquire necessary skills needed when writing effective essay paragraphs
Brief summary of overall task	Watch the following Videos and list key qualities of a well-argued essay: 1.http://youtube.com/watch?v=FGu5TK-Rvg 2.http://youtube.com/watch?v=TZQplyk 3.http://youtube.com/watch?y=NBiiRgZjfk

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Spark	WRITE TO LEARN “25 or 6 to 4” <i>Waiting for the break of day,</i> <i>Searching for something to say,</i> <i>Flashing lights against the sky,</i> <i>Giving up, I close my eyes,</i> <i>Sitting cross-legged on the floor,</i>
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	<i>Twenty five or six to four, Staring blindly into space, Getting up to splash my face, Wanting just to stay awake, Wondering how much I can take, Should I try to do some more Twenty five or six to four, Feeling like I ought to sleep, Spinning room is sinking deep, Waiting for the break of day, Searching for something to say, Twenty five or six to four; Twenty five or six to four.</i> <i>BY -ROBERT LAMM; from: College Learning and Study Skills by ;Longman,G.D&Atkinson,H.R</i> <i>My study cycle.</i>  <i>5 minutes later...</i>
Individual task	1. Which patterns of idea development appeal to you most and why?

	2. Study the two paragraphs and for each identify the main idea Write your answers in assignment 8.5.0
Interaction begins	1. Briefly discuss the difference between and argumentative and informative purpose 2. Study the two paragraphs above and discuss the different methods of paragraph development used to explain the main idea of each paragraph. 3. Discuss the roles of a topic sentence and other sentences in a paragraph of an academic essay. Post the responses in the discussion forum 8.5.0 and save a copy in the group portfolio.
E-moderator interventions	I will summarize and provide feedback to the responses within the week of the e-tivity then close the e-tivity at the end of the 7days.
Schedule and time	• Individual activities to take 2 hours • Group activities to take 2 hours
Next	Writing Argument

8.7.2 The Body Paragraphs

The body of an essay is made up of several paragraphs. Each paragraph attempts to advance or develop in more details the main idea that is stated or implied in the introduction. Each paragraph does this by methods that are determined by the overall purpose for writing that essay. There are various patterns used by writers to develop the idea in a given paragraph. These include definition, description, classification, argument, and cause and effect exemplification.

8.7.3 What Is A Paragraph?

A paragraph is a group of sentences developing a main idea. A well-written paragraph in an informative or argumentative essay should be:

- Unified: All sentences clearly relate to the main idea of the paragraph.
- Coherent: All sentences should be logically connected to each other.
- Fully developed: Paragraphs should have sufficient details to explain or expand the point or claim made in the paragraph. Use examples, facts, opinions, statistics, quotations, definitions, and so on.

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- Appropriately organized: Paragraphs should have a clear logical pattern of organization such as chronological, spatial, emphatic, narrative, cause-effect and

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comparison-contrast. Writers do not always use topic sentences because they have the skill to carry the reader along without explicit signals.

As a student writer, though, you are required to use explicit topic sentences so that your essay will stay organized.

See examples of two supporting paragraphs

1.

Probably the most difficult problem for people living alone is dealing with feelings of loneliness. First, they have to understand the feeling. Some people confuse being alone with feeling lonely. They need to remember that unhappily married people can feel very lonely with spouses, and anyone can suffer from loneliness in a room crowded with friends. Second, people living alone have to fight any tendencies to get depressed. Depression can lead to much unhappiness, including compulsive behaviours like overeating or spending too much money. Third, people living alone need to get involved in useful and pleasurable activities such as volunteering their services to help others.

2.

Throughout history we humans have tried to manipulate the food chain to provide ever-greater outputs of energy. On the one hand, we have tried, by whatever means we could employ, to rid our fields of harmful birds, insects and rodents, and our animals of diseases and parasites. On the other, we have constantly striven to produce healthier and more productive strains of plants and animals. Often these attempts have been spectacularly successful. Sometimes, though, the results have proved disastrous, as with the insecticide DDT.

8.7.4 The Topic Sentence

A topic sentence is the sentence that gives the main idea the writer intends to make and cohesion in a paragraph in which it appears. A good topic sentence does two things:

- It tells the reader what you are going to discuss in the paragraph (the topic)
- It establishes control so that you do not wander away from the basic purpose of your paragraph (controlling idea). In the examples below, the part in bold is the topic and the one in bold tells you what aspect of the topic the paragraph will focus on.

Colour filters offer three advantages in black-and- white photography.

Overeating, which is becoming an attractive pastime for the affluent of the world, has several dangerous effects.

However, not every paragraph begins with a topic sentence. Some professional

writers do not always use topic sentences because they have the skill to carry the reader along without explicit signals. As a student writer, though, you are required to use explicit topic sentences so that your essay will stay organized. See the links below for more information on topic sentences.

8.7.5 Using Facts and Opinions

Among the different types of details used to develop paragraphs are facts and opinions. A fact has to do with anything you say that is an actuality, a certainty or truth. It represents an act, deed, or event that can be easily verified especially physically. An opinion on the other hand has to do more with a feeling, a view, or a belief. Click on the links below for more information.

1. <http://www.umt.edu/writingcenter/docs/resourcesforwriters/waystosupportanargument.pdf>
2. <http://www.uefap.com/writing/function/argue.htm>
3. <http://www.emotionalcompetency.com/evidence.htm>

Assessment Questions

Read the sentences below and indicate whether it is a fact or opinion by ticking the correct option.

1. Warthogs are the ugliest animals on earth. (Fact/Opinion)

2. All cultures have greeting rituals. (Fact/Opinion)
3. That law was amended in 2015. (Fact/Opinion)
4. Football is more interesting to watch than rugby. (Fact/Opinion)
5. 2016 is leap year. (Fact/Opinion)

8.7.6 Transitional Paragraphs

If you are writing a lengthy essay, you may need a short paragraph or sentence that indicates a shift from one group of ideas to another. Transitional paragraphs play a number of functions such as to summarize the ideas that have so far been discussed, repeat the key ideas of the essay and indicate how new ideas may follow with the information presented in the preceding paragraph(s).

☐ Example of a transitional paragraph

Although the three factors we have examined above- illiteracy, disease and malnutrition, help - explain the magnitude of the problems facing children in difficult circumstances there is a fourth problem that seems to override all the rest. War now poses the greatest challenges of all.

☐ Note:

A transition paragraph stands on its own, separating as it were, two different sections of the essay, while a transition sentence is usually part of the paragraph that is concluding or introducing a new section. For more information read /watch the following links

1. <http://writingcenter.unc.edu/handouts/transitions/>
2. <https://pressbooks.bccampus.ca/technicalwriting/chapter/appendixd-transitionalwords/>
3. <http://literarydevices.net/transition/>

8.7.7 The Concluding Paragraph

The purpose of a conclusion is to bring the essay —home to rest— by signaling that the discussion has been completed. Not all papers require a separate conclusion. Narratives or descriptions stop when the writer finishes the story. The academic essay, however, does benefit from a conclusion that echoes the main point. To be effective, a conclusion must logically and stylistically connect with what the paper is all about. A long complex essay may end with a summary of key points, but shorter papers can end using some of the methods such as restating the thesis statement. That means repeating the

purpose that was at first mentioned in the introduction in different wording, for example-question, a prediction or a warning.

Example of a conclusion:

As seen from the above discussion, practicing good listening skills is difficult. The important lesson, however, is that if we are going to initiate and maintain good human relationships with others, we have no choice but to strive and improve our listening habits.

8.7.8 Creating Coherence in Your Paragraphs

Your paragraphs should be written in such a manner that all sentences logically relate to one another. We define coherence as that quality of the essay that makes it „hang“ together or feel connected. One creates coherence in a variety of ways such as using reference words and pronouns, repeating key words or their synonyms and using transitional signals.

Therefore, a good paragraph has unity (develops one main idea) and coherence (ideas logically hang together as one). Follow the links below for more information on coherence.

1. <http://www.wheaton.edu/Academics/Services/Writing-Center/Writing-Resources/Paragraph-Unity-Coherence-and-Development>
2. <https://owl.english.purdue.edu/owl/resource/606/01/>

8.7.9 Transitional Signals

Transitional signals are words or phrases that connect your ideas and ensure unity and logical flow of your text. These signals indicate the direction of your thoughts or ideas to your reader. The signals fall into various categories of those that: show cause and effect, indicate sequence or order, and introduce additional ideas, compare, and contrast. For more information on transitional signals, see the links below

1. https://www.uts.edu.au/sites/default/files/HELPS%20Transition%20Signals_0.pdf
2. <https://student.unsw.edu.au/transition-signals-writing>

8.8 Writing an Argument

E-tivity 8.8

Numbering, pacing and sequencing	8.8
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Title	Writing An Argument
Purpose	This activity will help you to acquire skills on how to write well-argued essays.
Brief summary of overall task	Watch the following video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?V=liyFKUFCQno) and list key qualities of a well-argued essay.
Spark	
Individual task	1. Differentiate between informal and formal arguments 2. Why is academic essay writing considered as a form of argument? 3. Why is inclusion of evidence and effective use of concrete arguments important in academic writing?

Interaction begins	1. What is plagiarism and why is it a serious academic offence. Post in discussion forum 8.6.0. 1. Why is acknowledging of sources an important requirement when you are writing an academic essay? Post in discussion forum 8.8 2. What is the difference between: • Intext – citation and footnotes • Reference list and a bibliography • Reference list and a bibliography. 4. Comment on the answers of one of your group members. Post in discussion forum 8.8
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E-moderator interventions	1. Summarize the contributions. 2. Give feedback and learning points. 3. Close the e-tivity a week from its commencement
Schedule and time	Spend one hour on individual tasks and another one on group tasks
Next	Revision

8.8.1 What is an Argument?

As a writing strategy, an argument involves the presentation of reasoning, evidence and logic in order to convince a reader to accept a particular point of view on a debatable topic. Generally, there are two types of arguments: informal and formal. Informal arguments take place mainly in day- to- day conversation in which case the speaker attempts to convince the listener to change his/her mind at whatever cost including using exaggeration to achieve that aim. This type of argument is called persuasion. Formal argumentation, on the other hand, relies more on authoritative opinion and logic to support a point of view and it appeals to the faculties of reasoning rather than emotions to convince the reader about an idea. You will notice, however, that some writers use the terms, argument and persuasion, interchangeably.

To succeed in argumentation, you will be required to parade carefully selected evidence, which may be in form of startling statistics, research findings, or views of experts in the field in which you are writing.

8.6.3 Strategies for Argumentation

Arguments have a conventional way in which they should be presented. This can be simplified as Claim (proposition) - Evidence - Argument and Counterargument. This involves:

- a. Making a claim or proposition (the statement of opinion that is presented for debate), e.g. most teenagers joining university today do so for reasons completely different from those for which universities have been established.
- b. Using supporting reasons and evidence (facts, cases, statistics, examples, authorities, anecdotes, scenarios, etc.).
- c. Handling counterarguments (involves acknowledging, accommodating and meeting opposing points of view).

8.8.2 The Claim

The claim, sometimes referred to as proposition or statement, is a declarative statement that is either true or false, but not both. The first step in preparing a convincing argument is to structure a clear, limited proposition. In the essay introduction, it is called a [thesis statement](#), while in a paragraph it is a topic sentence. You could do several things with your proposition. For example, you can attempt to convince the reader that something is or is not a fact and to take a particular action. Therefore, in order to generate an effective proposition make sure that, among other things, the point you intend to make is debatable. Avoid the following pitfalls in choosing topics for argumentative essays:

1. Presenting matters of fact. For example, “*Girls mature faster than boys.*”
2. Choosing issues that are simply a matter of personal taste. For example, “*Watching soccer is more interesting than hunting.*”
3. The proposition is clear. This means it is free of any ambiguous words that could allow for two or more meanings. In other words, it should not be open to misinterpretation.

4. The proposition deals with only one point, especially at the paragraph.
5. You define any words that need defining immediately in the next sentence. An argument cannot achieve its aim unless both you and the reader are clear about the meaning you attach to the terms you are using.

8.8.3 Qualifying Your Claim

If as a writer, you are very certain that your case is so strong that readers will accept your argument easily; you will need to state your position emphatically and unconditionally. Nevertheless, if on the other hand you have a feeling that your judgment or conclusion might be challenged, then you will be wise to qualify your claim. Readers tend to take a claim that is qualified seriously. However, if you over qualify your argument becomes shaky.

8.8.4 Checklist for Argument

As you edit your essay it is important that you make your argument is convincing. You do this by asking yourself the following questions.

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1. *Do I have a strong and clear statement in the introduction (thesis statement) that announces to the reader my proposition (the view I intend to put forth for debate)?*
2. *Are there words that I need to define before getting into the argument?*
3. *Have I paraded, in a logical manner, sufficient evidence to support my point of view? (facts, statistics, definitions, examples, anecdotes and so on).*
4. *Have I handled objections wisely by acknowledging the opposing side and attempting to show why it is weaker than the side I am proposing?*
5. *Have I acknowledged sources of information for any ideas that are not from my own head?*
6. *Have I used words appropriately; that is the right words for the intended meaning?*
7. *Have I avoided distorting information by presenting it accurately and completely?*
8. *Have I used the right tone of voice? For example, using a light warm tone for a light-hearted subject and serious tone for subjects such as war or ethnicity*
9. *Have I avoided over-simplifying a complex issue by suggesting rather simple answers to resolve the issue.*

8.9 Acknowledging Sources

Academic writing in college depends heavily on the ideas of others. If you do not acknowledge these sources, you will be accused of plagiarism, which is a serious academic offence. Some universities will have you fail a particular unit or even the whole course if you plagiarize. Actually, plagiarism is a form of theft, which takes many forms. For example, you will be said to have plagiarized if you:

1. Do not acknowledge texts or sections of texts borrowed from others in parenthetical references in the text or use footnotes.
2. Copy another student's paper and present it as if it were your own composition.
3. Do not provide a bibliography or list of references at the end of the essay/paper.

8.9.1 Checking for plagiarism in your writing

Fortunately, there are programs that can help you check if your work has percentages of plagiarism, so you do not have to do it manually. As it is with many programs, some are free while others require a subscription fee. Find out what is available in your university library. For example, the Kenyatta University Post Modern Library has Turnitin anti plagiarism monitor and training on its use is available.

8.9.2 Quoting, Paraphrasing, and Summarizing

We have already said earlier on that to write a good academic essay, you ought to rely substantially on ideas from authorities in your field of study. Incorporating these ideas is done through quoting (short and long blocked quotations), paraphrasing, and summarizing.

See [Summarizing and Paraphrasing in the Reading Skills section](#) of this module.

8.9.3 The Bibliography or Reference List

You may tend to think that your essay ends with your concluding paragraph but this is not the case. After your conclusion the "Bibliography", sometimes referred to as the "Reference List" follows. This is the list of all materials you used in writing the essay and includes both published and unpublished documents such as books/ebooks, periodicals such as peer reviewed journals, and seminar papers. It includes both what you have referred to directly in the essay in form of summaries, paraphrases or direct quotations and also those sources you consulted in developing the work. Reference list also refers to the list that follows the conclusion and is derived only from the materials that the writer has used in the body of the essay.

8.10 Collaborative Research and Writing

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8.10.1 Collaborative Research.

Lee, Y.S. & Schottenfeld, M.A. (2014) define collaboration as “a process of shared creation for a common goal, based on diverse perspectives and expertise in a group.” Need for collaborative research has grown in the 21st century. Collaboration is actually one of the core competencies for the 21st century workplace. The reasons for this are many. For example, the research environments are becoming more competitive, forcing people to look beyond their disciplines, organizations, and sectors. This helps them to share knowledge and skills in order to gain a competitive edge. Secondly, prevailing knowledge economy demands that societal needs are addressed through multi-sectoral approaches. Since collaboration offers an environment for creativity and critical thinking, collaboration is used as one of the approaches of promoting learning. Other than improving learning outcomes, it acts as a good avenue to practice work related skills, values and attitudes.

It is important to note that collaboration does not always flow smoothly. Problems could arise from lack of role clarity, coordination and performance of task and social aspects of the research. Collaboration creates a democratic space for members to contribute their ideas, which might lead to success. Success is, therefore, dependent on a number of factors such as role clarity.

8.10.2 Collaborative Roles

Having clear expectations from the start will facilitate smooth operations. Check chapter 4.3 in [Technical writing essentials](#) for more information on roles. Check table 4.3.4 in particular.

8.10.3 Collaborative Writing

Most writing is born of different types of collaboration. Academic essays at the university are no different. For you to turn in a quality product, it is important that you share your work with others for review. Your facilitators usually assign collaborative writing tasks as one of the requirements for a pass in the units. This is the case in UCU 110: Communication and Collaboration Skills, where you will be expected to write essays in a specified genre.

8.10.4 The Writing Project

The aim of the collaborative writing project is to help you research on a recommended topic in groups that are either pre-determined or formed by the students. The project takes the process approach, where you are given a chance to practice various skills introduced in different sections of the lesson. The assignments are phased in these corresponding sub-

sections of the lesson. For example, the note-making task is under reading skills in 7.2.4. Read [chapter 4.3 in Technical writing essentials](#) for an example of collaborative writing stages.

You will be provided with two spaces in Google Drive to help you collaborate. The links directing you to the spaces will be in the Learning Management System:

- Space 1: Working
- Space 2: Planning

The essay length is 1500-200 words written in APA style. Refer to 5.7.3 in this lesson for more details on APA style. [Read APA guide: 7th edition](#) for more details. Write in continuous prose without subheadings.

WEEK	TASK	GROUP/INDIVIDUAL	WORKING	PLANNING

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			SPACE (Google Docs)	SPACE (Google docs)
1&2	a. Get to know each other. b. Discuss how to work together. c. Brainstorm on possible argumentative essay topic based on one of your core units.	Group (a,b,c)		a. b.
3&4	a. Search for two relevant sources of information related to the topic and summarize key points. Write the sources using APA style b. Discuss how each of the contributions address the proposed topic.	a. Individual b. Group	Working space	
5	Write the thesis statement and prepare the essay outline	Group	Working space	
6	Make notes from two sources using linear notes	Group	Working	
7&8	a. Write the first draft. b. Select a peer reviewer from another group or year of study.	a &b Group	Group(a)	b. Post details of the peer reviewer
9	Post the first essay draft for guidance	Group	Working	
10	a. Arrange for peer review by someone outside the project group. b. The peer reviewer posts the comments	a. Group b. Peer reviewer	b	a. Post details of the peer reviewer.

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11	Refine the document using comments from the peer reviewer and your views.	Group	Working	
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12	Submit the essay	Group	Working	
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Table 8.10.4 Group project schedule. Adapted from [Nykopp, M., Marttunen, M. & Erkens, G. Coordinating collaborative writing in an online environment. *J Comput High Educ* 31, 536–556 \(2019\).](#)

8.11 Summary

In this lesson, we have presented information that will help you enhance adequate understanding of writing as a communication tool for learning at the university. The key features of academic writing, together with the stages one goes through to develop essays, have been examined. Because writing forms the primary means through which your performance as a student will be assessed, the lesson has highlighted those features and stages of writing that you have to come to terms with in order to write the kind of papers that will appeal to your assessors. Although skills in use of correct grammar and vocabulary are admired by your university examiners, they will be more pleased to see that you can interpret essay topics effectively; gather the relevant material for a given topic, especially through reading. Structure the ideas in your essay logically and demonstrate you can think clearly through the arguments you write. Furthermore, we have discussed the main parts of the essay and how they can be written in order to achieve a strong essay. Writing well-developed paragraphs are seen as some of the ways of achieving those goals. Once more we reiterate that good writing is achieved through collaboration and practice and that this lesson is concerned with illuminating some of the areas in which practice should be concentrated.

Lastly, we want to note that writing skills are interdependent with the other skills covered in this module. You will need in particular to pay careful attention to the information contained in reading and information and literacy skills.

8.12 Assessment questions

1. Academic writing is guided by certain c-n-e-t-o-s or rules.
2. Academic writing is a linear process. True/False
3. Lee, Y.S. & Schottenfeld, M.A. (2014) define collaboration as “a process of shared c-e-t-on for a common goal, based on diverse perspectives and e-p-r-ise in a group.”
4. Collaboration does not always flow smoothly. True/False
5. Plagiarism is also known as academic d-s-o-e-ty.

8.13 E-Resources

A primer on communication studies (v.1.0)(2012).

<http://2012books.lardbucket.org/books/a-primer-on-communication-studies/index.html>

Collaborative Research and Writing Skills

1. College success: Strategies for answering questions.

<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/waymaker-collegesuccess/chapter/text-strategies-for-question-types/>
3. Nykopp, M., Marttunen, M. & Erkens, G. Coordinating collaborative writing in an online environment. *J Comput High Educ* 31, 536–556 (2019).
<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s12528-018-9203-3>
4. Janssen, J., Erkens, G., Kirschner, P.A. & Kanselaar, G. (2012). Task-related and social regulation during online collaborative learning. *Metacognition Learning* 7, 25–43 (2012). [h ttps://doi.org/10.1007/s11409-010-9061-5](https://doi.org/10.1007/s11409-010-9061-5)
5. How to collaborate and write with others.

<https://courses.lumenlearning.com/atd-sanjac-englishcomp2/chapter/chapter-four-how-to-collaborate-and-write-with-others/>
6. Smith, J. (2019). Communication at work: A college-to- career guide to success.

<https://ecampusontario.pressbooks.pub/communicationatwork/>

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